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THE LAST SHERLOCK HOLMES STORY

THE LAST SHERLOCK HOLMES STORY

When Sir Arthur Conan Doyle wrote his detective stories, he never thought that Sherlock Holmes and Dr Watson would become so famous. But Holmes and the doctor live on, in story after story – long after their deaths. For when Dr Watson died, he left behind him a locked box, with orders that it must not be opened for fifty years. The box contained a report, written in the doctor's own handwriting. But why did he want it kept secret for so many years?

To find out, we must go back to the narrow dirty streets of Whitechapel in the London of 1888. Three women have been horribly murdered by Jack the Ripper. Scotland Yard is helpless – unable to stop the murders or catch the killer. So the police turn for help to the great detective, Sherlock Holmes . . .

'It is an extraordinary case, Watson,' says Holmes, his eyes bright with excitement. 'This is the criminal that I have waited for. To destroy him will be the greatest success of my life!'



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The Last Sherlock Holmes Story

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Foreword

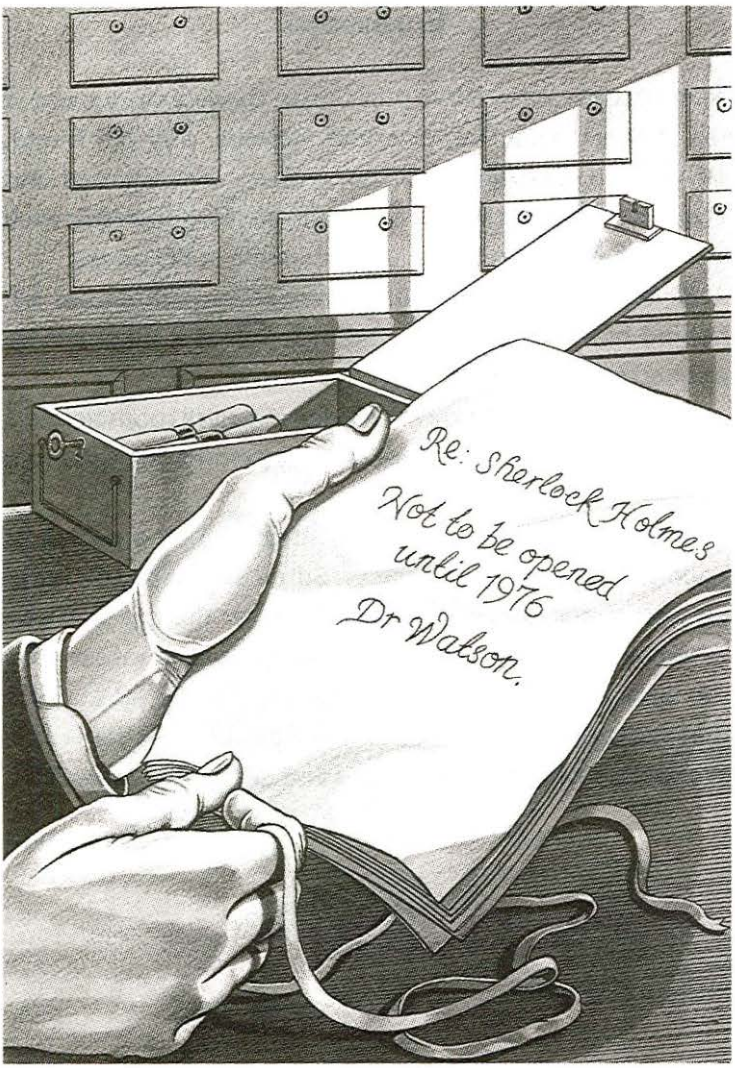
Many people enjoy Sir Arthur Conan Doyle's stories about the famous detective, Sherlock Holmes, and his friend, Dr Watson. But who now remembers that Holmes and Watson were real people? Everyone has forgotten that they lived before Conan Doyle gave them life in his books.

Dr Watson died in 1926. He was seventy-three. He left behind him a locked box, and orders that it must not be opened for fifty years.

For fifty years the box lay hidden in a dark room below a bank. Years came and went, and the world changed in a thousand ways.

In 1976 the box was opened. It contained a packet of papers. They tell a terrible story. Some people say it cannot be true. They say Watson was lying, or that he was sick when he wrote it. After so many years we cannot be sure. We have checked all the facts that we can. All we know is that the story could be true. It is possible. We think it is probable. Now you must read it and decide for yourself.

THE EDITORS



In 1976 the box was opened. It contained a packet of papers.

Introduction

How well my friend Arthur Conan Doyle would tell this story! How exciting and interesting he would make it. I cannot do that. I am no writer. I have been a doctor and a soldier. All I can do is make my report.

But who will read my words? What will the world be like in 1976? Perhaps by then nobody will know the names of Sherlock Holmes and Jack the Ripper. Perhaps all Conan Doyle's wonderful stories will be forgotten. There is so much to explain. I must ask my reader to be patient!

I had known and worked with Sherlock Holmes for almost four years when I first met Arthur Conan Doyle – ACD I always called him. Like me, he was a doctor, and we quickly became good friends. He told me amusing stories of hospital life, and I told him about my life as an army doctor in Afghanistan.

I often talked to him about Sherlock Holmes. At that time most people had never heard of him. Only the police and some criminals knew what a great detective he was. ACD seemed to enjoy my stories very much. He was never too tired to hear about another of Holmes's cases.

We met many times and enjoyed many good dinners together before I realized that ACD had a special interest in Holmes. He wanted to be a writer, and had already enjoyed a little success. Now he wanted to write about Holmes, using the facts of a real case, but adding his own ideas to the story. I found this an excellent idea. I was happy to think that my

dear friend would become famous.

I explained the plan to Holmes. He listened in silence, his pipe in his hand. Then he said, 'Can he write, this friend of yours? Can he tell a true story? Does he understand the difference between facts and lies?'

'I think so,' I said. 'He has just begun to write, but already he is becoming fashionable.'

'Fashionable!' Holmes said coldly. 'How can it interest me that he is fashionable? Can a fashionable writer have a serious interest in the facts of one of my cases?'

I could not reply. Holmes sat silently, looking into the fire. At last he said, 'Well, he may try. Let him do what he can. You may send him your notes on the Hope case, Watson.'

I wrote to ACD the next day, and he began work on the story. He called it *A Study in Scarlet*. When it appeared in the shops, I hurried out to buy it, and then sat for hours in a park reading it. The story was excellent – fast-moving, exciting and clever. I ran back to Baker Street. I could not wait to give the book to Holmes.

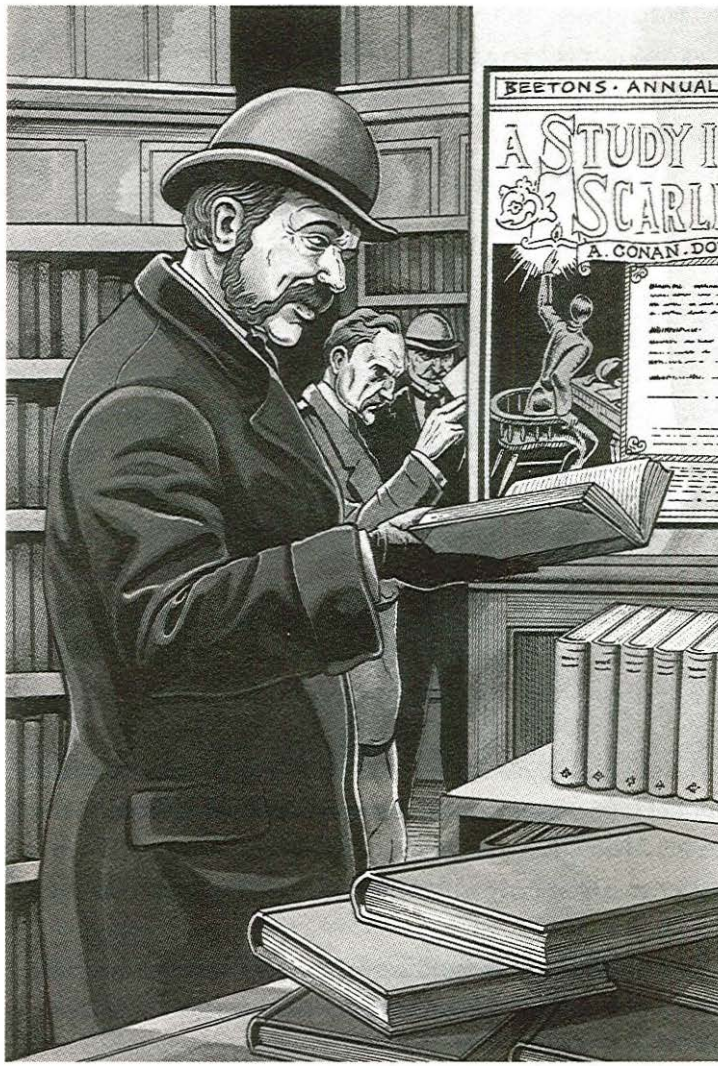
He looked up quickly as I entered the room.

'You're late, Watson,' he said. 'Were you ashamed to come here with that book in your hand?'

'Ashamed, Holmes?' I cried. 'No! ACD has done well. I see you have read it. Why don't you like it?'

I was soon sorry that I had spoken.

'Like it? It is rubbish, wild and fantastic rubbish. He has been careless with the facts, added all kinds of unnecessary lies, and made the most stupid mistakes.'



When the book appeared in the shops, I hurried out to buy it.

'But Holmes . . .'

'I wonder what kind of doctor he is. I am sorry for his patients. I would not be surprised to hear that he had cut off a man's leg because the man had a stomach ache. He is clearly not interested in facts.'

'Holmes,' I said as calmly as I could, 'a writer does not just report facts. He must make sure that the story is interesting to read. I am sure you understand that.'

Holmes smiled at me sweetly.

'My dear fellow,' he said. 'I forget. You know all about fine writing. How stupid of me to worry about a few careless mistakes! But your friend Mr Doyle has shown that he does not understand how important my work is. He thinks that the criminals I fight against are stupid, miserable little beings. They are not. I fight against evil itself. He has failed to understand that. The book is worthless. Away with it, and with your friend the writer!'

I wondered what to say to ACD, but there was no need to worry. *A Study in Scarlet* was not a success, and he began to write about other things. Several years later he decided to write about Holmes again, but at that time I had other things to think about. I had fallen in love with Miss Mary Morstan. When she agreed to become my wife, I hurried to tell Holmes. I was full of happiness.

I can still hear the cold surprise in his voice as he said, 'I cannot pretend to be happy about this.'

This hurt me terribly, but I tried to laugh.

'Well, Holmes,' I said, 'I hope you won't be too lonely when



I had fallen in love with Miss Mary Morstan.

I go home to my wife.'

A shadow passed over his face.

'Oh no, Watson,' he said. 'I still have my cocaine-bottle.'

Was he asking me for help? Was it still possible, then, to save him? Perhaps. In my heart I know only that my dear friend needed me, and that I failed him.



The first murders

Sherlock Holmes became a detective in 1877, four years before I met him. At first he enjoyed every case, but soon he began to find the work easy. Ten years later he was famous, but he was unhappy and bored.

'The modern criminal is so painfully slow and stupid,' he often said. 'I need an interesting case, Watson, one which will make me think. Are there no clever thieves or murderers in the world these days?'

It is dangerous for a very intelligent man like Holmes to become bored. Some days he grew violent and once he shot several bullets into the walls of his room. He also began to use cocaine.

Does my reader know about cocaine, I wonder? Perhaps it is no longer used in the world of 1976. It is a useful medicine, and doctors rightly give it to patients who are in pain. But Holmes had no disease of the body. He used cocaine as a drug, because he enjoyed it. It made the long days seem more exciting. Soon he needed it every day, and could not live without it.

I told him to stop, but he only laughed at me. 'My dear fellow, I wish I could! Only bring me an interesting case, a difficult problem, and I shall forget my cocaine!'

One day in 1888 a note arrived from Scotland Yard. When Holmes opened it, he laughed and jumped to his feet.

'Inspector Lestrade wishes to see me,' he said. 'The police

need my help, Watson. You know, of course, that someone is murdering women in Whitechapel?'

'Of course,' I replied. 'The newspapers are full of it. Three women are dead, and the police seem unable to find the killer. Everybody knows this. Life is cheap on the streets of Whitechapel for women of that kind. What can interest you in their miserable deaths?'

'It is an extraordinary case, Watson,' Holmes cried. 'I have been studying it. I knew the police would need my help. Shall I tell you the facts?'

'Please do!' I said. Was this going to be one of Sherlock Holmes's great cases? I hoped that at last he had found something to interest him.

'The women who died were poor, and neither young nor beautiful,' he told me. 'So they were not killed for money or for love. Why were they killed? That is one mystery. There is another. Each woman was killed with a knife. The word "killed", Watson, cannot describe the violent and terrible ways in which they were murdered. They were cut up like meat. The stomach of one was opened, the head of another almost cut from her body. But this is not the worst. There are things that even the newspapers will not describe.'

He showed me a doctor's report on one of the bodies. As I read it, a sick feeling came over me.

'What man could do this?' I asked. 'What possible reason could he have to do this to a woman? Why, Holmes, why?'

He smiled coolly at me.

'Why indeed? That is the real interest of this case. In

themselves, these deaths are not important. Women like that are murdered every week. But why does this killer cut them up? Why rip the bodies to pieces with a knife? That is the question which makes this case so exciting!'

If anyone can stop these terrible murders, Holmes is that man, I thought. This case could become his greatest success.

At that moment somebody knocked at the door.

'Ah, come in, Inspector,' Holmes said. 'I understand you have finally decided to ask me to help you catch this Whitechapel murderer.'

Inspector Lestrade did not look very pleased. 'Not at all, Mr Holmes,' he said. 'I was just passing Baker Street, and I know you find these cases interesting.'

'How kind!' Holmes said. 'Please tell us. When did you arrest the killer? I am a little sad, I must say, to find that you have done it all without me.'

'We haven't arrested anyone yet,' Lestrade said, 'but I am very hopeful, Mr Holmes. You see, I have in my pocket a letter from the killer himself.'

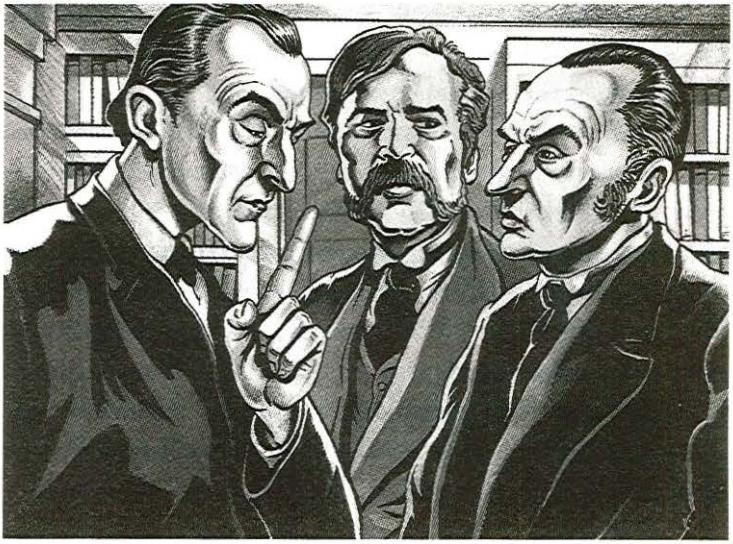
The smile left Holmes's face. He was suddenly serious.

'May I see the letter?' he asked.

It was written in red, and the name at the bottom was 'Jack the Ripper'. I still remember something of what it said:

I love my work. My knife is nice and ready for the next job. I can't wait to rip again.

Holmes turned to Lestrade. 'What are you doing to stop this murderer?' he asked. 'It is clear that he will kill again very soon.'



'May I see the letter?' Holmes asked.

'Every extra policeman that we have will be in Whitechapel at night,' Lestrade said. 'And we have a little surprise for Jack the Ripper.' He looked at us importantly. 'Some of our best and bravest policemen will be dressed in women's clothes,' he said. 'We will stop at nothing to catch this criminal.'

There was a moment's silence. Then Holmes and I looked at one another and we both began to laugh. We could not stop.

Lestrade turned very red. 'I see you are amused by murder,' he said. 'You do not wish to work with us. Well, I am a busy man. I must leave you. Goodbye, Mr Holmes. Goodbye, doctor.'

Holmes stopped laughing immediately.

'Inspector,' he said, 'I want very much to work with you. Let us meet this afternoon to discuss our plans.'

This made Lestrade much happier.

When he had left, I said to Holmes, 'You have laughed at the police, but what ideas do you have about these crimes? Who do you think the murderer is?'

'I do not know who he is, Watson,' he told me, 'but I believe I know what kind of man he is. He is far too intelligent, too extraordinary a killer for our good friend Lestrade and his policemen in dresses to catch. No, he shall be mine. He is the criminal that I have waited for. To destroy him will be the greatest success of my life. I dream of it, Watson! I must destroy him! I cannot fail!'

He was shaking with excitement. I had never seen him like this before.

That afternoon he went to Scotland Yard. When he came home, he was very quiet. Next day he appeared dressed in old, dirty clothes.

'I am going to Whitechapel,' he told me. 'As you know, I have rooms in several parts of London. For the next three days I shall live among the poor people of Whitechapel. Nobody will know who I am. I shall talk to them and listen to everything that they tell me.'

'May I come with you?' I asked, but he said, 'No, Watson, you may not. If there is a murder, I shall send for you. I shall need your help, old fellow, have no fear of that!'

I spent a lonely evening in Baker Street. I was asleep when, at half past two in the morning, a cab arrived to take me to

Whitechapel. Another woman had met a violent death.

As I travelled through the dark, empty streets, London seemed a strange and ghostly place – it lay there like the body of a great animal, not sleeping but dead.

The driver took me east, towards the poorest parts of the city. He stopped in a narrow lane off Leadenhall Street. I saw a group of policemen standing under a light, and went up to them. Holmes was not there, but I was introduced to the police doctor. He offered to show me the body.

'I know you are a doctor,' he said, 'but I must warn you. You have never seen anything like this before.'

He led me to a dark corner, where something lay covered on the ground. He held up a light for me to see and pulled back the cover.

No words can describe the awfulness of what I saw then. For a moment my head felt light, I began to shake and was afraid I would fall. The thing on the ground had been a woman, but it was not a woman now. It was no more than blood and meat, cut open and ripped up with a terrible, unnatural violence. I knew now why the killer called himself Jack the Ripper.

The doctor covered the body, and I walked back to the group of policemen.

'Have you seen Mr Holmes?' I asked one of them.

'Oh yes, sir,' he said. 'He was here with Inspector Lestrade. They came straight from the other murder.'

'The other murder!' I cried. 'Has there been more than one murder tonight?'

'Why yes, sir. Did you not know?'

At that moment I heard the sounds of a horse coming into the lane, and a cab appeared.

'Get in, Watson!' a voice shouted, and Holmes helped me into the cab.

'He has escaped,' he told me. 'We followed him, but we have lost him.' His face was sad and tired. 'I want to show you something interesting. Then we can go home.'

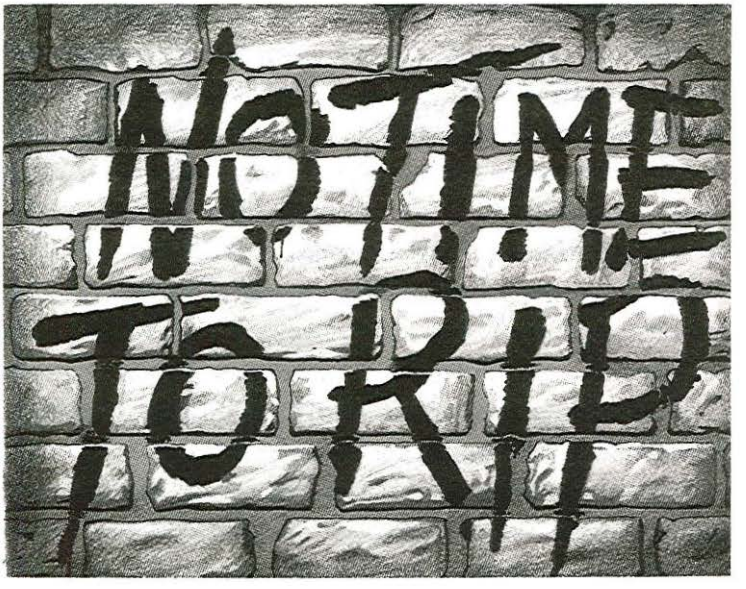
The cab took us to a dark and dirty yard.

'The first woman died here,' Holmes said.

A policeman was standing in the yard. Holmes took a light from him and shone it on the wall.

'Look at this, Watson,' he said.

These words were written on the wall:



'It is the murderer's hand-writing,' Holmes said. 'The same as in the letter that Lestrade showed us.'

'What is happening?' I cried. 'I cannot understand what this killer wants.'

'He wants everybody to be afraid of him,' Holmes told me. 'He wants to be the most evil killer in the world. He had to kill two women tonight, because he did not have time to cut and rip the body of the first. I think he heard somebody coming, and he had to leave the body and run. Then he killed a second time, and cut that woman's body to pieces in the way we have seen.'

We were both silent as the cab took us back to Baker Street, far from the narrow, dirty streets of east London.

I could not sleep that night. Every time I closed my eyes, I saw the body of a woman lying in a dark corner, covered in blood.



Professor Moriarty

Sherlock Holmes was busy with other cases for the next three weeks. There were no new murders in Whitechapel, but people were frightened and angry with the police, who were no nearer to finding the killer than before.

My own life was happy enough. I visited my dear Mary Morstan, and kept this visit a secret from Holmes – something which made me feel unusually clever!

One day Holmes and I had just finished breakfast together.

He was standing by the window, when suddenly he gave a cry.

'What is it, Holmes?' I asked. 'What's the matter?'

He turned towards me. His face was white and the look in his eyes was terrible.

'May I have an hour of your time, Watson?' he asked in a low voice.

'Of course, but . . .'

'Then get your hat and coat.'

He ran out of the house. I followed him quickly and the next two hours passed in a wild chase all over London. We jumped into a cab, out of it again and onto a train, ran down narrow streets and in and out of a big hotel. Finally we came to rest in the peace of a London park.

'You are a true friend, Watson,' Holmes said at last. 'You came with me without a question. Did you realize that someone was following us?'

'I thought so. But who?'

'Can you not guess?'

'No.'

'He calls himself Jack the Ripper.'

'Holmes!' For a moment I found it difficult to speak. Then I asked, 'Did you see him through the window? Where was he?'

'In the empty house opposite ours. He was watching our rooms, Watson. He knows that I am looking for him. We must be very careful. He is one of the most dangerous criminals in Europe.'

'But who is he?' I cried.

'Have you ever heard of Professor Moriarty?'



Two hours passed in a wild chase all over London.

'Never.'

'That is the strangest and most terrible thing about him.' Holmes laughed angrily. 'He is everywhere, but nobody knows him. Like his crimes, he is fantastic.'

I listened in silence as Holmes told me about Moriarty.

'He is an extraordinarily intelligent man. At the age of twenty-one he was a professor of mathematics. For years he was one of the most important men in the world of mathematics. Then he disappeared from university life. Soon after that I began to realize that crime in London was changing. Someone was telling criminals – who are usually stupid and uninteresting little men – what to do. They were obeying the orders of a mastermind. It could only be Moriarty. But I could never catch him. I hate his crimes, but I recognize his intelligence. He is the only criminal who interests me, because he is the only criminal who is as intelligent as I am.

'Then, in August, everything changed. Criminals became stupid again. In the middle of all his success, Moriarty had disappeared. Why?'

'Holmes!' I cried. 'The reason is clear. The Whitechapel murders began in August. It must be . . .'

'No, Watson,' Holmes said. 'It is not clear. Someone like Moriarty does not break locks and climb through windows himself. He gave orders to others. He was the commander-in-chief of the criminal world, not a foot-soldier.'

'Then why . . . I mean, how . . .?'

'Success is too easy for him. He needs change and danger as others need drugs. He was the best at mathematics, then the best

at crime. Now he has chosen murder.'

'Do you mean that he kills just to amuse himself?' I asked.

'Yes. He enjoys the danger. But there is another reason. He wishes for a battle with me – the most successful criminal against the most successful detective. It will be a fight to the death.'

'Then these women that he kills . . .'

'They mean nothing to him. He just uses them because they are necessary to his plan.'

'His plan?'

'Yes. I have said that he kills because he is bored and because he wishes for a fight to the death with me. There is a third reason. He wishes to destroy the world we know.'

'He is mad!'

'No. He is not mad. He is evil itself. He wants to bring fear into our lives, to make everyone in London afraid to go out at night, afraid of every sound and shadow. London will become a city of strangers, seeing danger in every neighbour. How can people live like that?'

He was silent for a moment. Then he said, 'I alone can stop him. And stop him I shall.'

Several days later, Inspector Lestrade called to see us again.

'Are you ready to arrest the Whitechapel killer yet?' Holmes asked him.

'We are continuing to make all possible . . .'

'Enough, Lestrade! Have you caught him yet?'

'In a difficult case like this . . .'

'Yes or no?'

'No,' Lestrade said, 'but we hope . . .'

'Of course we hope. We must always hope. But the people of London will not wait for ever for the police to arrest Jack the Ripper. Do you think you could enjoy life as a policeman in Canada, Lestrade?'

Lestrade tried to smile. He said, 'I believe we shall only catch him if we have the luck to find him while he is actually murdering some poor woman.'

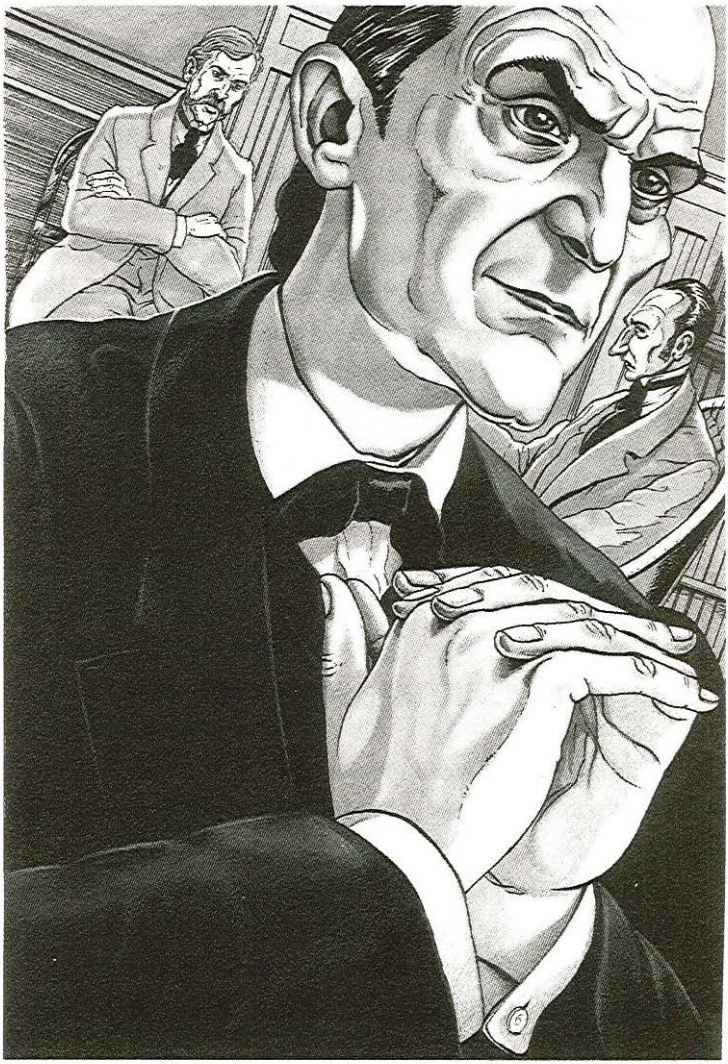
He looked surprised when Holmes said, 'That is the first sensible thing I have heard any policeman say about these murders. We must catch him red-handed. A drink, Inspector?'

'Yes, please, Mr Holmes. But who can say when or where he will kill again?'

'I can,' Holmes said coolly. 'Let us look at the dates of the murders. He kills, waits a week, kills again and waits three weeks before the next murder. This changes only when he has, as he tells us, 'no time to rip', and has to kill twice on the same night. The following week there is no murder. I tell you, Lestrade, this is no crazy killer. This is a man who is following a plan. He works only in Whitechapel, and in the early hours of the morning.'

Lestrade looked helplessly at him. 'What shall we do?' he asked.

Holmes jumped to his feet. 'I think he will try to kill again on Monday night. The first murders were on a Friday, a Saturday and a Sunday. He moves a day forward each time. We must close up Whitechapel like a box which he cannot escape from.



'We must close up Whitechapel like a box.'

We shall need every policeman you have.'

Lestrade looked worried. 'I'll do what I can, Mr Holmes, but I don't know if my chief will like it.'

'Your chief,' Holmes said, 'will give you all the men you need. I am sure that you will be interested to learn that your chief has asked me to do anything I can to catch this killer. I am free to give you orders, Lestrade, and you are free to obey me.'

When Lestrade had gone, Holmes said, 'Now I need a bath, my dinner and a good sleep. Moriarty wishes to destroy me. He has already, my dear Watson, tried three times to kill me! He is a terrible enemy, and I must get ready for the battle.'

I stared at him in horror, and decided that I would never leave my friend's side while he was in this danger.



Jack the Ripper kills again

On Monday night Whitechapel was full of policemen, all ready to catch Jack the Ripper. Nothing happened. Only Lestrade enjoyed this.

'You have failed, Mr Holmes,' he said. 'Your idea was very clever, but you made one mistake. You forgot to tell the murderer about it!'

Holmes and I took a cab back to Baker Street. We were both too tired to talk then, but later that day I said, 'Holmes, what did happen? What went wrong?'

'We did not really fail. Moriarty could not kill anyone because we were there. But I badly wanted to catch him at his work, and there I failed.'

'He was there, then?'

'He was there. He saw what I had done, and realized that he could not kill a woman that night.'

'Then you did not fail! We have beaten him.'

Holmes shook his head slowly.

'No, Watson. We have not beaten him yet. Think how angry he must be! I have stopped him once, and now he will try harder to kill me. He will go on with his planned murders, and he will do everything possible to make sure that he succeeds.'

'But Holmes, how do we . . .?'

'Remember, he kills, waits a week, kills again and then waits three weeks. So he will kill again next weekend. I must talk to Lestrade. But tonight, Watson, we shall amuse ourselves at the theatre.'

He would say no more, but that night, while we were at the theatre, he disappeared from my side without a word. I did not even see him leave, and for several days I neither saw him nor heard from him. Then, at dinner time on the night when we had hoped to catch Jack the Ripper at his work, he suddenly appeared again in Baker Street.

'Holmes!' I cried. 'Where have you been?'

'Don't worry, old fellow.' He sat down by the fire. 'I have been keeping Moriarty busy and playing games with him. He has chased me all over the country, but, as you see, I am still alive. I shall tell you my adventures some other time. Lestrade

will be here in a minute to discuss tonight's plan.'

When Lestrade arrived, he did not seem at all pleased to see us.

'So, another of your clever little plans, Mr Holmes,' he said coldly. 'Do you really think we shall see the killer tonight?'

'He will be at work tonight,' Holmes replied. 'The only question is, shall we be ready for him? I suppose you have done everything that I ordered you to do?'

'We are ready for him.'

'Then let us go. We must not keep Jack the Ripper waiting.'

It was a cold, windy night, and we were grateful for our thick coats as we sat in the cab. It took us to the big police station in Commercial Street. Hundreds of policemen were waiting there to begin the night's work. Holmes and I sat down to wait, too.

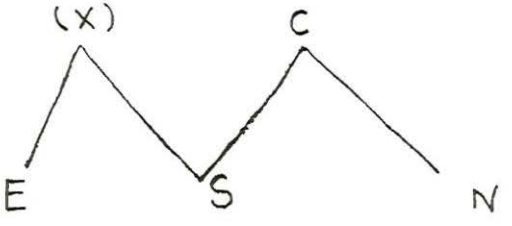
After some time I said to Holmes, 'This waiting is terrible. I wish we could do something.'

'We can,' he replied.

'When a crime is reported. Until then we can only wait. The murderer could be anywhere out there.'

Holmes picked up a piece of paper and a pencil. 'He could. But I think I know where he is. Look at this.'

This is what he showed me:



'The letters E, S, C and N are Eddowes, Stride, Chapman and Nicholl, the last four women he has murdered,' Holmes said. 'The diagram shows the place where each died.'

'And X, I suppose, is some unknown woman, the one that he plans to kill tonight,' I said. 'But how do you know where to put the X on your diagram?'

'Look again, Watson,' Holmes said with a smile.

Suddenly, I understood. 'It is a letter M!'

'Yes, Watson. M for murder, M for . . .'

'Moriarty! Holmes, do you mean to say . . .?'

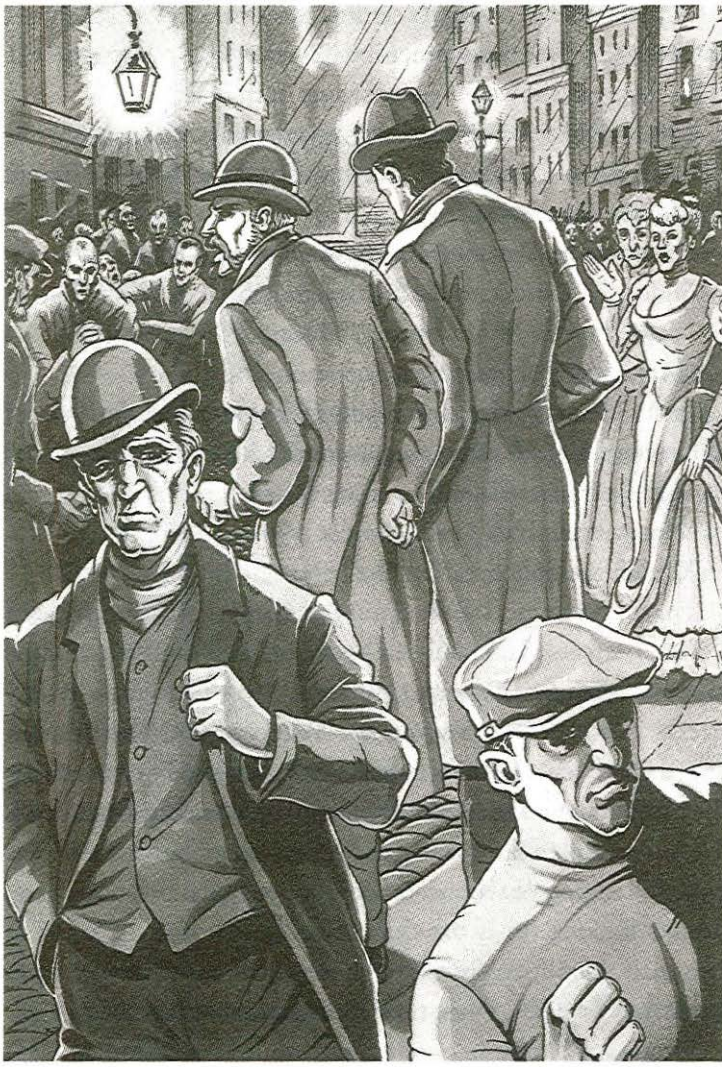
'Yes. He is writing his name in blood upon the face of Whitechapel. And, as you see, I know where he will try to kill tonight, and where I shall go to meet him.'

'Not without me,' I said. 'I must come with you.'

We left the police station just before midnight.

For the first time, I walked through the narrow streets of east London, streets that I had seen before only through the window of a cab. People think that murders happen in dark, empty streets. That is not always true. A strange and horrible fact about the streets where Jack the Ripper murdered women is that they were busier and better lit than most other London streets. They were full of pubs and cheap hotels. At all hours the streets were full of people who were too poor to find a bed anywhere, drunks looking for a bar that never closed, and all kinds of criminals. Finally, there were the women – those women who work only at night, when their more honest sisters are asleep.

I studied medicine in London, and while I was a student I saw something of the low-life of our capital. I was, after all, a healthy



For the first time, I walked through the streets of east London.

young man, and young men must amuse themselves. But I had never seen women like these. Holmes stopped several to question and to warn them, and I looked at their faces carefully. They were old at the age of twenty, dirty, diseased and hopeless. One thing was clear to me – they were not like other women. Does it matter, I began to think, if Jack the Ripper kills women like these? Death by his knife is quick. It cannot be worse than the slow and painful death from disease which most often ends their short lives.

We returned to the police station after one o'clock. I was tired and sick at heart. Lestrade did not stop talking, telling us that we should catch no murderers that night.

Suddenly, Holmes jumped up and walked out into the street. I followed him.

'Stay inside, Watson,' he said. 'You are tired, dear fellow, and you cannot help me.'

'I am coming with you,' I said. 'Nothing will stop me.'

'Come, then. But we must hurry. Moriarty is near. I can feel it.'

It began to rain. He walked fast and I almost had to run to keep up with him. His eyes moved restlessly from side to side. Suddenly he stopped, and stared into the darkness.

'Twice, Watson,' he said softly. 'He will kill twice tonight. We stopped him killing a woman last time, so he must kill two tonight.'

Before I could answer, he was moving again. Then he stopped, and pulled me into a dark corner. Someone was coming towards us. Holmes spoke in a low voice, but I shook

with fear at his words.

'It is Moriarty.'

A man passed our corner and disappeared into another street. I could not see his face.

'Run to the police station and fetch Lestrade. He knows what to do,' Holmes said. 'I shall follow Moriarty. Hurry, man, hurry!'

Then he was gone. I cannot explain why I did not do what I was told. The fact is, instead of going to the police station, I followed Holmes. Perhaps I was afraid that my friend could not fight Moriarty on his own.

I ran to the corner of the street. I could just see Moriarty, walking straight on. Then, to my great surprise, Holmes turned left, and disappeared into a house, while Moriarty reached the end of the street and turned the corner. I could not understand what was happening, or what I should do next. What if Holmes, realizing that someone was following him, thought I was one of Moriarty's men? Some minutes later, I was still wondering what to do when I heard a door close. A man came out into the street. It was Holmes. He was now richly dressed, in a hat and a long, dark coat. He had changed his appearance in several small and clever ways, but I knew him.

I wanted to call to him, but was afraid he would not be pleased. Instead, I decided to follow secretly, ready to help him if he needed me.

We walked and walked. The rain became heavier and the streets emptied of people. Then a short fat man passed me, and soon afterwards a girl. She looked like a woman of the streets,

but younger and prettier than most I had seen that night. She seemed a little drunk, and could not walk straight.

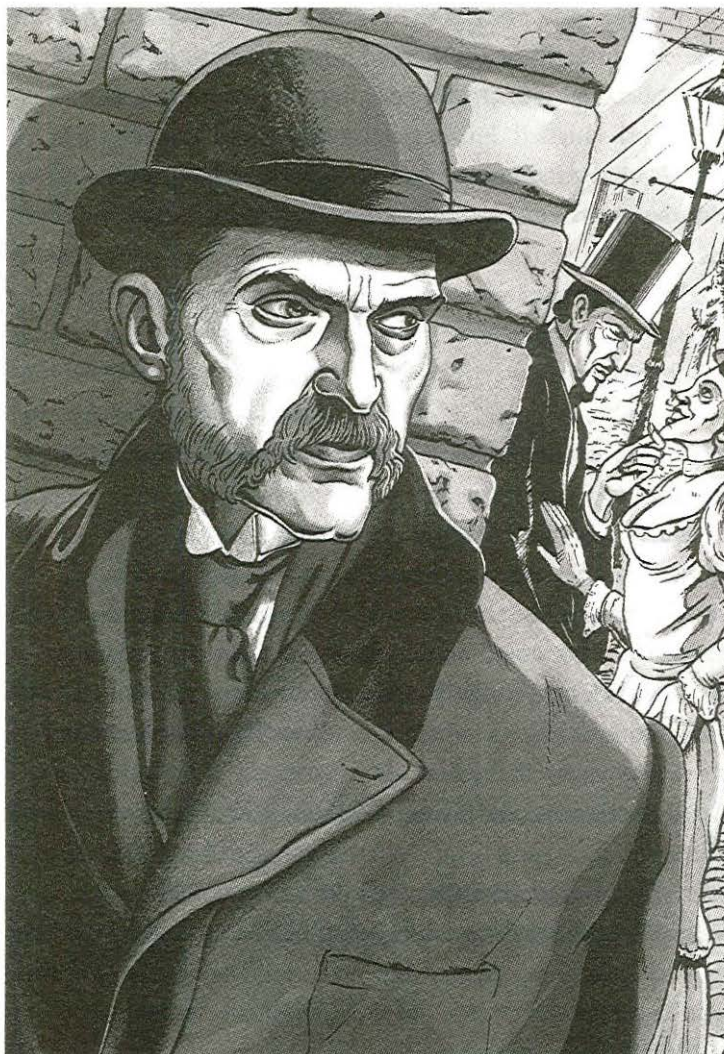
As she came near to Holmes, he stopped and spoke to her. They both laughed. Further along the street I saw the short fat man, now standing outside a pub, watching them. Then Holmes and the girl walked off together and a few seconds later the man followed them. How I feared for Holmes's safety! I was sure that the man and the girl were working for Moriarty. They had some plan, I knew, to hurt my friend. Perhaps only I could save him.

Holmes and the girl walked on, the man followed them, and I followed all three. At last Holmes and the girl stopped at the entrance to a yard. I heard the woman's voice. I could not hear Holmes's words, but to my surprise I clearly saw him kiss her face. Then they entered the yard, and the fat man crossed the street and went into a house further along. Had he gone to fetch Moriarty, who would now appear and kill my friend?

Slowly and carefully, I made my way into the yard. It was dark, but I could see a light at a window. Then I heard Holmes's voice. He was in that room.

As quietly as I could, I went to the window. The curtains were a little too short, and I could just see into the room. The woman was lying on the bed, drinking from a bottle. Holmes sat with his back to the window, taking snuff from a little silver box. He seemed to be in no danger, but who could say when Moriarty would arrive?

It was cold and wet in the yard, but I felt calm again. If Moriarty came, I was ready to save my friend. I sat down with



As the girl came near to Holmes, he stopped and spoke to her.

my back to the wall to wait.

I am ashamed to say what happened next, but I must say it. I fell asleep. I was asleep for two hours. As I woke up, cold and uncomfortable, Holmes's words came back to me, 'He will kill twice tonight.'

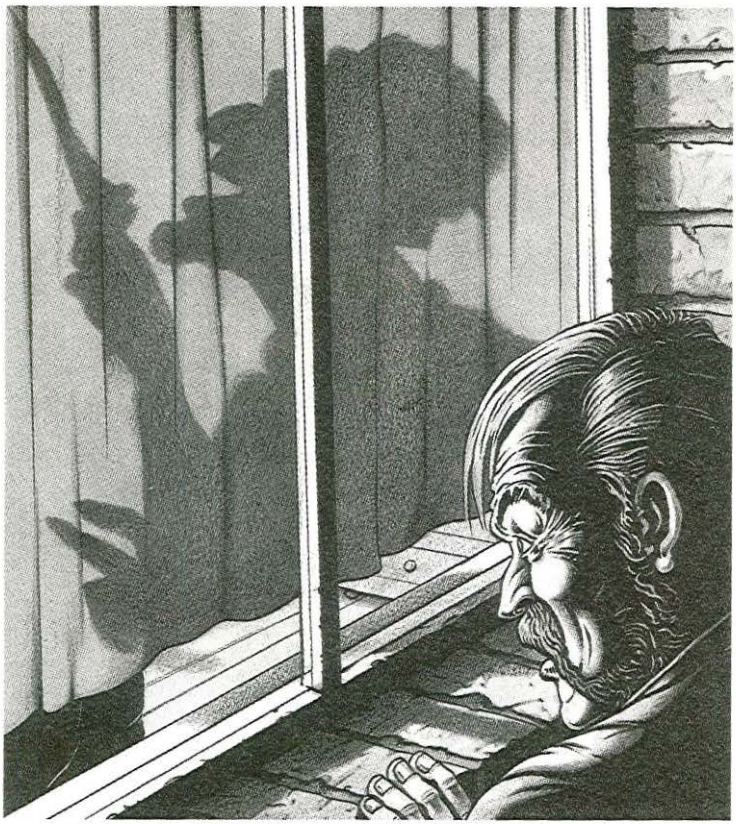
I ran to the window, afraid of what I should see. At first I could not understand what terrible thing had happened there. Was it possible, I wondered, for a person to explode? There was blood everywhere. Then I recognized the body as the woman who I had seen drinking and talking with Sherlock Holmes. He was still with her, but he was not dead. No, much worse than dead. He was alive. He had a knife in his hand, and he was cutting up her face and her body. Even as I watched, he was carefully cutting the leg down to the bone, taking off a long piece of meat in his other hand.

And as he cut the woman to pieces, he was singing.



Moriarty is dead

As a soldier and a doctor, I know that a man who is very badly hurt in battle often feels no pain. If he lives, he remembers nothing about what has happened to him. After that terrible night in Whitechapel, I was like that man. The next day, I woke up and found myself lying in a park. My watch and my money had gone, and I was cold and dirty. I knew that I had spent many



He had a knife in his hand.

hours drinking, but I did not know where I had been, or what had happened to me.

I did not want to go to Baker Street, because I was afraid that Holmes would be there, but I needed a bath and dry clothes. In the end, I paid a cab-driver to knock on the door. The house

was empty, so I went in.

There was a telegram from Holmes. 'M has escaped us,' it said. 'He is trying to leave the country, but I am following him.'

I did not know what to think. Was I mad, or was my best friend, the man who I had worked with for so many years, a murderer?

That evening, the murder in Whitechapel of a young woman called Mary Kelly was reported in the newspapers. This murder was more bloody, more horrible than any that had happened before. It was clear that it was the work of Jack the Ripper.

I was still reading the newspaper reports of the murder when Lestrade arrived.

'Good evening, doctor,' he said. 'I'd like a word with Mr Holmes.'

I did not know what to say. Did the police already know what Holmes had done?

Then Lestrade saw the telegram, picked it up and read it. 'Running off for a little holiday, is he?' he said. 'Some of us have to work for a living. We've had enough of Mr Holmes and the kind of help he gives the police.'

'Come now,' I said. 'Holmes was right. There was a murder on the night he told us that there would be.'

Lestrade laughed. 'Oh yes. There was a murder all right. We had hundreds of policemen on the streets, but we couldn't stop the murder or catch the killer. The police were everywhere – except the little corner of Whitechapel where the girl died.'

He spoke in a low voice as he continued, 'I've never seen anything like it. It will be days before I can eat meat again.

You're lucky you didn't see her, doctor. We had to keep the worst thing of all out of the newspapers, but I can tell *you*. The girl was pregnant. He cut her up, and he cut up the baby, too.'

I felt a cold hand touch me. 'He will kill twice tonight.'

'What did you say?'

'Oh, nothing. What are you doing to catch him?'

'What can we do? Nobody heard a scream or saw anything.' He looked again at the telegram. 'Who is this "M"?' he asked.

'Oh, he just means the murderer,' I said.

After Lestrade left, I tried hard to think of some other way of explaining what I had seen that night. I had seen Holmes cutting up the body, but I had not seen him kill the girl. How could my dear friend possibly be this terrible killer? Perhaps it was all part of some clever plan that I did not understand.

For some days I thought I had found an answer to the problem, but then a telegram arrived from Holmes, who was now in Switzerland. It said, 'M is no more. Returning Saturday. Holmes.'

Suddenly I realized that I was afraid of seeing him again, and my worry returned, stronger than ever. Was he the killer or not? I had to know the truth – and quickly. To help me think clearly, I wrote down what I knew.

Is Sherlock Holmes the Whitechapel murderer?

The arguments for:

1 He was in Whitechapel on the nights of the murders, and alone at the right times.
2 When he was out of London or I was with him, there were no murders.

3 He can change his appearance easily.
4 He studied medicine. He could easily cut up a body in the dark.
5 He knows the lanes and yards of Whitechapel well.
6 He can escape from the police because he knows their plans – indeed, he makes their plans.

The arguments against:

1 He spends his life fighting crime.
2 I know my friend. I know he could not do these things.

When I read what I had written, I began to wonder how well I knew Holmes. Did he really fight against crime? He took cases because they interested him, not because he hated crime. It was all just a game to him. He fought crime to amuse himself.

It was now late at night. I was terribly tired, but I knew that I had to decide what to do before Holmes came back. Suddenly, as I lay back in my chair, half-asleep, the terrible picture of Holmes cutting up that girl's body appeared again before my eyes. Then, finally, I knew. It was not *what* I had seen him do, but *how* he had done it. That look of cool amusement on his face. The way he sang as he worked. The man who could do that could do anything.

Next day I packed my bags and moved into a hotel. That evening I asked Mary to have dinner with me. I told her that I could not sleep while she lived alone in London and the Whitechapel murderer was free to kill again. I asked her to marry me sooner than we had planned. She laughed and said she was not afraid of the murderer. He never killed women like her. But she would marry me as soon as possible, she said, because I



I had to decide what to do before Holmes came back.

looked so worried and unhappy.

Then I wrote a letter to Holmes.

'I am sorry that I cannot welcome you home,' I wrote, 'but I have a reason for that, the best reason in the world. Mary and I are married. She was badly frightened by those awful murders in Whitechapel and will feel safer now that I am by her side.

'It is wonderful to hear from you that Professor Moriarty is dead. Of course I look forward to hearing the full story of his death from you.

'Mary and I are spending a little time travelling. Please write to me at my London club.'

Several days later, Mary and I were married, and we left London. In a quiet little town by the sea, with Mary by my side, I felt strong enough to face the awful truth about Holmes, and to think about what I had to do. I could not go to the police with my story. They would think that I was mad. I decided that I would have to watch Holmes carefully. Only I could stop him killing again.

When I returned to London, I found a letter from Holmes waiting for me at my club. He told me that he was going to Russia, to work on a strange and exciting murder case.

'I am bored with London, now that Jack the Ripper is dead,' he wrote. 'Perhaps the foreign criminal has more to offer me. I shall not return to London for some time. Please inform me of your new address.'

After reading this, I was happier than I had been for many

weeks. Mary and I finished our holiday and moved to a house in London, not far from Baker Street. I was busy with my work as a doctor, and we lived quietly and happily together.

During this time I was sent two wonderful letters by Holmes. He had brought his work on the Russian mystery to a successful end, and had gone from Russia to Ceylon, where the sudden death of a rich tea-planter offered him the interest and excitement he needed. The Holmes who wrote these letters to me sounded like the old Holmes that I knew.

'He is dangerous when he is bored and uses cocaine,' I thought. 'When he is enjoying his work, London is safe.'

One day in March, as I walked along Baker Street, I saw a light in Holmes's window, and knew that he had returned. I went in, and he welcomed me like the dear old friend he had been. All evening we sat by the fire, and he told me everything that had happened in Russia and Ceylon. But what I really wanted to hear about was Moriarty's death, and about that he said not one word.

At last I could wait no longer.

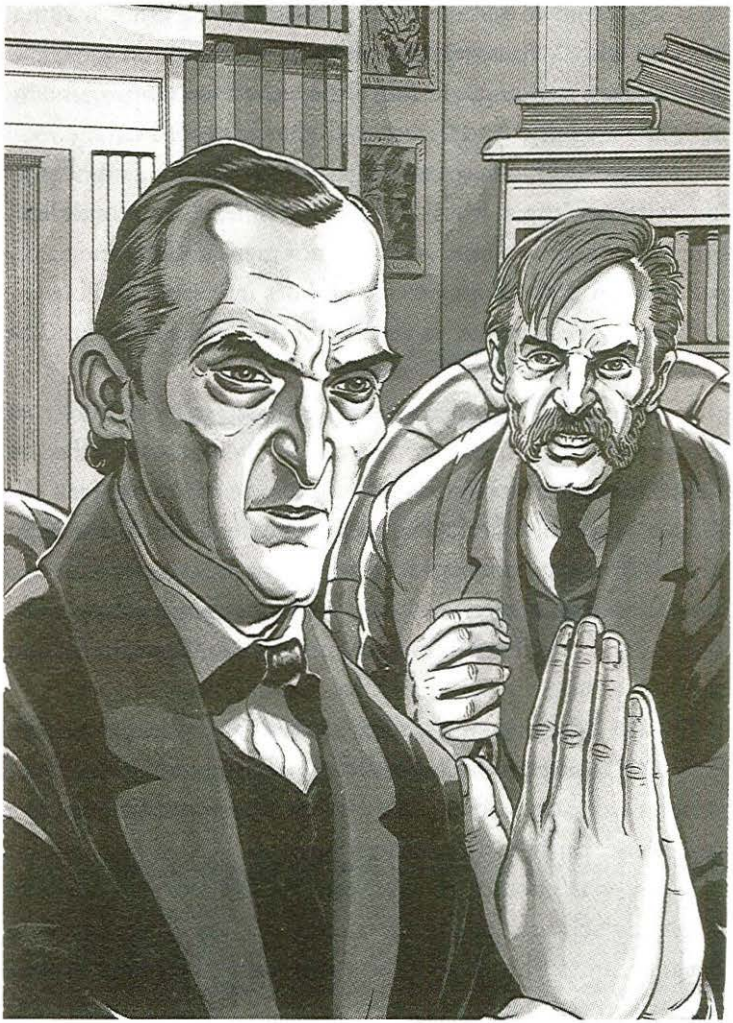
'My dear Holmes,' I said. 'It is almost midnight, and you still have not told me how Moriarty died!'

At once his face went white, and his eyes became fixed in a stare. He sat silent and unmoving, as the seconds passed.

Then he said, 'I'm sorry, Watson. I was thinking about something to do with my last case. What did you say?'

'Moriarty,' I repeated. 'You have not told me how he died.'

'He has gone,' he said. 'That is all that anyone needs to know about him.'



'He has gone,' Holmes said. 'That is all that anyone needs to know.'

I asked him to tell me more, and found out that his final meeting with Moriarty had been in Switzerland, on a narrow path above a famous waterfall. Holmes had won the argument, he told me coldly. And that was all that he would tell me.

Holmes and I were friends again, and soon I began helping him with new cases. It was just like old times. I am afraid that I often left my wife alone, and I did not give enough time to my patients, but I was happy to see Holmes interested and busy.

One day he gave me his cocaine-bottle. 'Take it, doctor,' he said. 'I do not need it any more.'

I was very pleased indeed at this news, and only one thing that happened at this time worried me. A woman was killed in Whitechapel, and people began to talk again about Jack the Ripper. I carefully checked where Holmes had been on the night of the murder, and found that he had spent the evening with two famous foreign detectives. I even spoke to them both secretly, and so I was sure that Holmes had not been in Whitechapel that night.

In 1890 I decided that I must begin to spend less time with Holmes. I wanted to be a success as a doctor, and I knew that I was not working hard enough for that. Mary and I moved to a new house, further from Baker Street.

There was another change, too. ACD's story, *A Study in Scarlet*, which had failed in this country, was a big success in America, and he began to write about more of Holmes's cases. To my surprise, Holmes quickly agreed to let him do this. He had been angry when he first read *A Study in Scarlet*, but now he seemed amused by what ACD was doing.

1891 began, and life for me was calm and happy. I was working hard, and I had little time to spend with Holmes. Jack the Ripper was a thing of the past, as forgotten as yesterday's newspapers, as dead as the women he had murdered. But Jack was not dead. He was only resting, and his rest would soon be over.



Death at the Reichenbach Falls

In February 1891 a woman called Flora White was killed with a knife in Whitechapel. Everyone thought that the murderer was Jack the Ripper. I alone knew that this was not true. I was sure that 'Jack' had not killed the last two women to die on the streets of Whitechapel.

Soon after this, Holmes left for France. He sent me a strange letter from there which worried me very much. I could not understand a word of it and began to wonder if he was taking cocaine again. This was his letter:

> If you remember the Berlin case of 'one in three', Watson, everything will be clear to you because . . . *the famous German professor in Paris is no longer alive. I heard he was recently killed while studying flora in the White Mountains of my favourite island. Letters and books are appearing soon. Read them quickly but carefully, as I cannot always follow or*

understand him myself. Last night I dreamt and the next day suddenly understood this problem. The time comes when he and others will be free – not an easy escape.

About three weeks after that, I was sitting alone at home one evening. My wife was away on a visit. Suddenly, the door opened, and Holmes came in. He then ran to the window, closed it and locked it.

'Holmes,' I cried. 'What has happened? You look terrible!'

He looked old and ill, and he was shaking with tiredness.

'What is it?' I asked. 'Are you afraid of something?'

'Of someone,' he said. 'Did you not get my letter?'

'Yes, but I didn't understand it. What is wrong?'

Holmes looked at me sadly. 'You didn't understand it. Is your wife here?'

'No, she is away. Do you want to sleep here? I shall make sure that you are in no danger.'

He shook his head. 'I cannot rest anywhere. If I sleep, he will win! I cannot stay here. I would bring evil into your house. But you can help me, Watson. I must leave the country tomorrow. Will you come with me?'

'Where are you going, Holmes?'

'Going? I am not going anywhere. I am trying to escape from him. But he will find me again. Everywhere I go, he will follow me.'

'Who is he, Holmes?' I asked.

'Professor Moriarty, of course!'

'But Moriarty is dead,' I said.



'What has happened? You look terrible!'

'Dead!' he screamed. 'He is trying to kill me! How can he be dead?'

'But you told me that he was dead.'

'I was mistaken,' Holmes said. 'He is not dead. I told you that.'

'You told me? But when? Where?'

'In my letter, man! The Berlin case – every third word! A very easy hidden message, Watson. I thought even you . . . Oh, it doesn't matter. The fact is, Moriarty is alive and free in London. He killed a woman only three weeks ago. He will kill again if I do not stop him. It is a fight to the death between us. Come with me and help me, Watson. Say that you will come!'

'Of course I will come, old fellow,' I said.

He smiled and lay back in the chair. In a second, he was asleep. Quickly, I gave him an injection to keep him asleep. Then, with the help of my cook, I put him to bed and locked the bedroom door. After that I had a drink and sat down to think about what I must do.

Perhaps I did not understand Holmes's hidden messages, but I did understand what was happening to the man. He was mad – I knew that now. All that was evil in him he called Moriarty. The fight with Moriarty was a battle that was taking place inside his own head.

I had hoped that Jack the Ripper was dead. He was not, and now another woman had been murdered. I felt that her blood was on my hands. The time had come when I must tell Holmes what I knew about him. First, I had to be sure that I understood everything.

I took a cab to Baker Street, and went into Holmes's rooms. I did not know what I was looking for, but I began to search. The rooms were untidy, full of old newspapers. I searched for four hours but found nothing. At four o'clock in the morning I stopped. I went to the window and looked out at the dark sky.

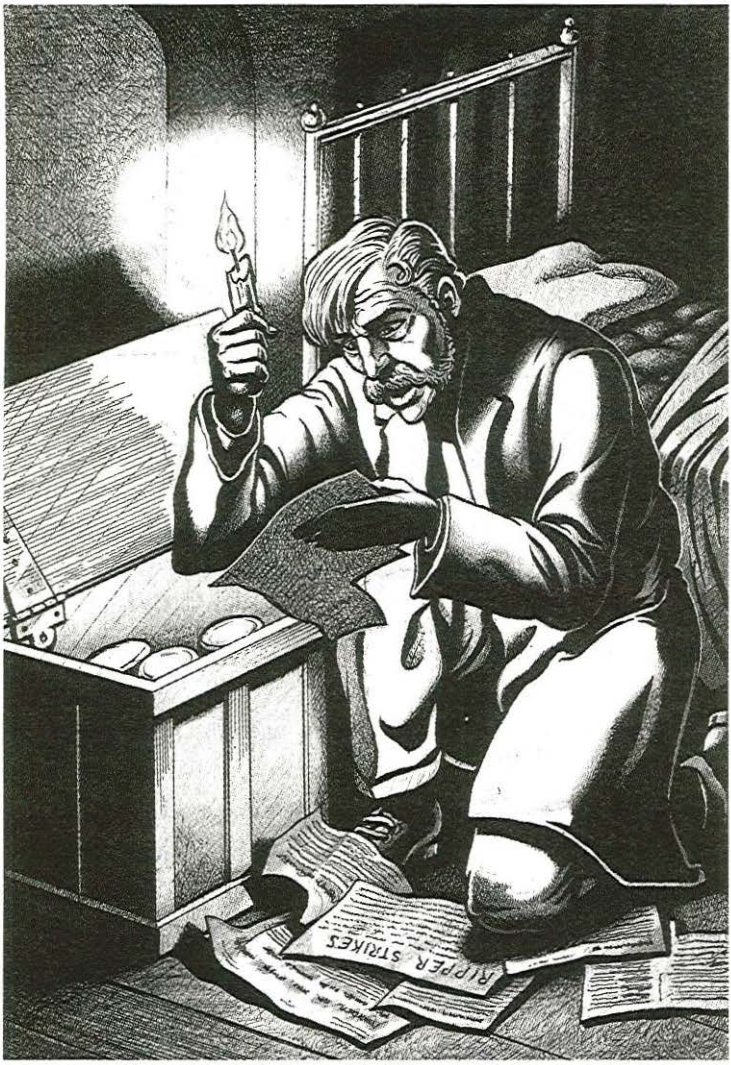
Suddenly, I knew what to do. The house opposite, where Holmes had once seen Moriarty. I ran across the street and broke the lock on the back door of the house. Every room was empty, all except one bedroom. This contained a bed, a cupboard and a box full of papers. All the papers were about the Whitechapel murders. Some were cut from newspapers, others were written by the killer himself. He described each murder with a sick enjoyment of what he had done.

Under the papers I found some glass jars of the kind that are used in hospitals. In them were pieces of women's bodies. In the last jar was the worst thing of all – pieces of the body of a little unborn child.

When I saw that, all the friendly feelings I had ever had for Sherlock Holmes died inside me. Now I could go straight to Lestrade and ask him to arrest Holmes, but I chose not to do that. I did not want all England to know what Holmes, once a good and wise man, had become. Some evil things are best hidden from the world. I, and I alone, would face him and his crimes.

I went out into the cold morning air. I felt strangely calm, but also excited.

Holmes was still asleep. I searched his clothes for drugs and guns, but found only a little money and his silver snuffbox. Then



All the papers were about the Whitechapel murders.

I wrote a letter to Lestrade. I told my cook to take it to my bank manager. If I failed to return, I asked him to send it to Lestrade. In the letter I told Lestrade everything that I knew about Sherlock Holmes and the Whitechapel murders.

I was very tired, but I knew that I had to stay awake. I had to watch Holmes all the time. I decided to use the cocaine he had given me. I added water to the drug and put it into a medicine bottle. Then I injected some into my arm.

It was time to look in on Holmes. As I opened the door, I saw that his bed was empty. He was behind the door. He tried to hit me, but the drug made me quick, and I jumped out of the way.

'Watson!' he cried. 'Dear fellow! I thought you were Moriarty. One of his men is in your garden. We must go now! It is too dangerous to stay here!'

The man who he had seen was William, my gardener.

'I will go and pack,' I said.

'No luggage! He must not know what we are doing!'

'Let me take my doctor's bag,' I said. 'He will think that I am going to visit a patient.'

'Excellent!' Holmes said. 'I had the same idea myself.'

He did not know that I had packed the cocaine, money and a gun in my doctor's bag.

Holmes sent me out before him to find a cab. We drove through the streets, jumped out of the cab, ran some way, and found another cab. But at the station, Holmes said, 'Moriarty is here. He has followed us. We must change trains as soon as we can.'

We jumped from the moving train, ran across fields, caught

another train, and at last took the night boat from Newhaven. For five days we travelled through France and Germany in the same wild and crazy way. Holmes would not say where we were going. I never took my eyes off him during those days, but the right moment to talk to him never came. Holmes seemed stronger than ever, while I was getting weaker every day. Only the cocaine made it possible for me to stay awake.

Finally, sitting one night in a hotel in Switzerland, I knew that I could not go on much longer. I had told Holmes that next day I wanted to walk over the mountains to the famous Reichenbach Falls. I decided that I would tell him what I knew about him when we were alone in the mountains. The cocaine was almost finished. Whether I lived or died, the end must come that day.

We did not begin our walk to the Reichenbach Falls until the afternoon. Holmes refused to go out before lunch. I was frightened. I had no more cocaine, and soon I would be too tired to go on. At last we left the hotel, and started to walk along the mountain paths. Holmes talked happily as we went. He found the mountains very beautiful.

When we had gone a little way, I found that I had left my watch at the hotel. It had belonged to my father, and I wanted to know that it was safe. I told Holmes that I would return to the hotel, find the watch, and see him later at the Falls. I hoped that I was doing the right thing, and that he would not disappear.

When at last I reached the Falls, I could not see him, and thought for a moment that he had escaped me. Then I saw a narrow path which was cut into the rock right above the Falls themselves. Holmes was standing on that path, watching the

water crash down onto the rocks. There was nowhere he could run to. It could not be easier for me.

I moved towards him. Suddenly he turned and our eyes met. His look was cool, untroubled. How could I hope to frighten this man? My heart failed me and I almost fell. He stepped forward to help me, but I pulled out my gun.

'Back!' I shouted. 'Another step and I shall shoot!'

He smiled. 'Very well, doctor. I understand.'

My hands shook and I almost dropped the gun. 'It's over, Holmes,' I said. 'I've been to the empty house. I know everything.'

He laughed. 'Dear fellow! Nobody knows everything!'

I seemed to hear voices coming to me from the water, and I could now see two Holmeses – one on the path and one standing on air.

'I've found the jars, Holmes, and the papers. I know you killed them.'

'I killed them? Which? The jars or the papers?'

Nothing seemed real. It was getting harder and harder for me to speak. Holmes watched me, smiling.

'I know you did it, Holmes,' I shouted. 'I watched you cut Mary Kelly to pieces. You killed them! Let me hear you say that you did!'

'What is it you want me to say?'

'Say you killed them!'

'You killed them.'

'I am going to shoot you, Holmes!' I screamed. 'Before you die, tell me that you understand what you have done!'



'I am going to shoot you, Holmes!' I screamed.

'You're mad, doctor,' he said. 'And you're talking rubbish. Go on, shoot me!'

I shot him. I shot again and again, but still he stood there.

Finally, I fell to the ground. I could not move. It seemed a long time before I could say, 'Why aren't you dead?'

I stared up at him as he stood above me, calmly inhaling snuff from his snuffbox.



'I took the bullets from your gun and put in blanks,' he said conversationally. 'Tell me, Moriarty, when did you kill Watson? You are very clever. You look almost like him, but I know who you are. When I saw you injecting cocaine three times a day, I knew then for sure that you were not my dear friend. Dr Watson would never, never take drugs. Your cocaine is finished, isn't it? Poor Moriarty! Did you not realize that my

snuffbox contains cocaine, not snuff?'

I felt sick and weak. Before my eyes Holmes was changing colour – red, then green, then blue. I shook my head to clear it, but he was still talking.

'And your letter, telling Lestrade that I was the Whitechapel murderer. What rubbish! How Scotland Yard would laugh! But I have the letter here – I saw it in your cook's hand and took it from her while you were calling the cab. You have failed, Moriarty. I have enjoyed making you run around Europe with me, but now you must die.'

He took out a long knife.

'Holmes!' I cried. 'I am Watson, your friend, Watson! I have tried to save you – save you from yourself and from the police!'

He held up the knife and stepped towards me.

'If you kill me,' I screamed, 'Moriarty will win! That is what he wants! Kill your only friend, and Moriarty has won!'

I closed my eyes and waited for the pain and the darkness.

It did not come. I opened my eyes and saw that Holmes was looking at me. He had put the knife down. The look in his eyes was sadder than anything that I had ever seen. He seemed to see far into both the past and the future, and to find them sad beyond words.

'Never fear, old fellow,' he said. 'I shall not let him hurt you.'

Then he stepped backwards off the path. I saw his body hit the rocks far below.



'I shall not let him hurt you,' Holmes said.

Conclusion

Two days later I woke up. I was in bed at the hotel. Someone had found me on the edge of the path, high above the Reichenbach Falls.

After a week I returned to London. I went immediately to the empty house, where I burned the papers and destroyed the jars. I wanted to be sure that nobody would ever know the evil things that Holmes had done. I wanted only the good that was in my friend to live on after his death.

I was lucky. ACD had been busy writing more stories about Holmes. These stories were an immediate success. ACD became a famous writer, and people who had never met Holmes the man, knew Holmes the story-book detective. As the years passed, people began to forget that Sherlock Holmes had ever been a real person.

After Holmes's death my life was difficult for a long time. It was two years before I could live without cocaine. I could not work, and my wife and I had little money.

My story is at an end. Since Holmes's death I have lived quietly. But sometimes, as I sit by the fire in the evening, I think of that day at the Reichenbach Falls. I hear again the gentleness of Holmes's last words, and see the light of understanding in his eyes during those last moments, when he seemed once again the best and wisest man I have ever known.





Sometimes I think of that day at the Reichenbach Falls.

GLOSSARY

blank blanks in a gun make a loud noise when the gun is fired, but no bullets come out

cab an old kind of taxi, which was pulled by horses

case a crime or a problem that the police or detectives are working on

city a large and important town

club a building used by the club members where they can stay, have meals, read the newspapers, etc.

cocaine a dangerous drug which is usually taken through the nose, as a white powder

commander-in-chief the head of an army

curtains pieces of cloth hung up in front of windows

diagram a drawing or plan that explains something

drug a dangerous medicine (e.g. cocaine) which some people take to get excitement and to make them feel different

drunk *(n* and *adj)* a person who has drunk too much alcohol

evil *(adj* and *n)* very bad

falls *(n)* a waterfall; a place where a river falls from a high place to a lower place

fellow *(informal)* a man

flora all the plants of a particular area

horrible frightening, terrible

horror great fear or dislike

inject to put medicine or a drug into the body with a special needle

injection putting medicine or a drug into the body with a needle

inhale to breathe in through the nose

jar a container or pot, usually made of glass
kiss to touch someone, usually someone you like or love, with your lips
lane a narrow street
mad crazy, with a sick mind
mastermind someone very intelligent, who plans other people's work (or crimes)
mathematics the science of numbers
path a narrow way for people to walk on
patient *(n)* a sick person who goes to a doctor for medical help
pregnant expecting a baby
professor the highest level of teacher in a university
red-handed (catch someone) catch someone in the middle of doing something wrong
rip *(v)* to cut violently with a knife
Ripper *(n)* a name given to a murderer who cuts people up
safety being safe, out of danger
scarlet bright red
Scotland Yard the headquarters of the London police
snuff tobacco, as a powder which is taken in through the nose
telegram a quick way of sending a message by electric wires or radio
truth the facts; what is true, what really happened
waterfall a place where a river falls from a high place to a lower place
weak not strong
wise knowing many things; knowing what is right and good
yard a piece of hard ground with buildings all round it

The Last Sherlock Holmes Story

ACTIVITIES

ACTIVITIES

Before Reading

1 The title of the book is *The Last Sherlock Holmes Story*. Why do you think it is the last story?

1 A criminal will murder Holmes.
2 Holmes will become bored with working as a detective and decide to do something different.
3 He will die in an accident, while chasing a criminal.
4 He will kill himself.
5 The police will not let him work on any more cases.

2 Read the back cover and 'About the Story' on the first page of the book. What do you know now about this story?

1 What did Dr Watson leave behind when he died?
2 How long did the box stay locked?
3 When did this story happen?
4 Where did it happen?
5 Who was the criminal that Holmes had waited for?
6 Why did Scotland Yard turn to Holmes for help?

3 Here are the names of four men in the story. Which of them were real people? And what is each man famous for?

1 Arthur Conan Doyle
2 Sherlock Holmes
3 Dr Watson
4 Jack the Ripper

4 **Two of the chapters are called *Professor Moriarty* and *Moriarty is dead*. Can you guess who Moriarty is? Choose one of these answers.**

1 An old friend of Sherlock Holmes
2 Another detective
3 A very clever criminal
4 The real name of Jack the Ripper

5 **There are two mysteries in this story – the mystery of Dr Watson's locked box, and the murder mystery. Can you guess what happens? Choose the best answer or answers to these questions.**

1 Why didn't Dr Watson want anyone to read his report until fifty years had passed?
   a) Because he had done something wrong and did not want the police to know that he was a criminal.
   b) Because he had seen terrible things, and did not want his wife and family to read about them.
   c) Because he knew a secret about Holmes and did not want anyone to know it until many years later.
2 What happens to Jack the Ripper?
   a) He murders more women in Whitechapel.
   b) Sherlock Holmes shoots him.
   c) The police catch him without Holmes's help.
   d) Dr Watson finds out who he really is.
   e) He is never caught, and just disappears. Nobody ever hears of him again.

ACTIVITIES

While Reading

Read the Foreword and Introduction. Choose the best question-word for these questions, and then answer them.

What / When / Who

1 . . . did the locked box contain?
2 . . . was the box opened?
3 . . . did some people say about Watson?
4 . . . wanted to write about Sherlock Holmes?
5 . . . did Sherlock Holmes think of *A Study in Scarlet*?
6 . . . fell in love with Mary Morstan?

Read Chapter 1, and then answer these questions.

1 What happened when Holmes was bored?
2 Why did Inspector Lestrade need Holmes's help?
3 How did the police plan to catch Jack the Ripper?
4 What did Holmes plan to do in Whitechapel?
5 What was written on a wall near one of the dead women?

Read Chapter 2, and then rewrite these sentences with the correct information.

1 Watson knew all about Professor Moriarty.
2 Holmes thought Moriarty killed because he was mad.
3 Nobody knew when Jack the Ripper would kill again.
4 Holmes had to obey Lestrade's orders.

Read Chapter 3, and then answer these questions.

1 What did Holmes do between Monday and the following weekend?
2 How was Moriarty 'writing his name' on London?
3 Why did Watson decide to follow Holmes secretly, instead of running to the police station?
4 What did Holmes do to the girl which surprised Watson?
5 Why didn't Watson see who killed the girl?
6 What was Holmes doing as he cut up the body?

Read Chapter 4. Are these sentences true (T) or false (F)? Rewrite the false sentences with the correct information.

1 Holmes left England after the death of Mary Kelly.
2 Holmes sent a second telegram to Watson to say that he was still chasing Moriarty.
3 Watson hoped that Holmes was not the killer, but he needed to know the truth about him.
4 Mary was badly frightened by the Whitechapel murders.
5 When Holmes came back to London, he wanted to tell Watson all about the death of Moriarty.
6 Watson and Holmes never worked together again.

Before you read Chapter 5 (*Death at the Reichenbach Falls*) can you guess who will die there, and how?

1 Jack the Ripper
2 A woman
3 Inspector Lestrade
4 Sherlock Holmes
5 Dr Watson

ACTIVITIES

After Reading

1 In Chapter 5 we get Dr Watson's side of the story. But how did Sherlock Holmes see things? Join these parts of sentences from a passage in Holmes's diary.

APRIL 1891, LONDON

1 I know Moriarty is alive, . . .
2 And he will kill again and again, . . .
3 I tried to explain this to Watson in my hidden message, . . .
4 Never mind. He has agreed to help me in my fight, . . .
5 It is too dangerous to stay here in Watson's house . . .
6 Yes! I have just seen one of his men in the garden . . .
7 but the stupid fellow didn't understand my letter.
8 as I am sure that Moriarty and his men are watching it.
9 because he has killed another woman.
10 and together we will follow this evil murderer.
11 so I must call Watson and we must leave at once!
12 if I don't stop him.

2 Now complete the last page in Holmes's diary with these linking words. (You will need to use some more than once.)

and / because / but / since / when / which / while / who

APRIL 1891, SWITZERLAND

I have enjoyed myself _____ we left England. I knew that something was wrong _____ I found my bedroom door was

locked in Watson's house. I tried to hit the man _____ came in, _____ he jumped away. And then there was the letter to Lestrade, _____ said that *I* was the Whitechapel murderer – what rubbish! I took it from the cook's hand _____ Watson was calling the cab – _____ it wasn't Watson, of course. No, Moriarty had killed my poor friend _____ taken his place. I know this man is Moriarty _____ I have seen him injecting himself with cocaine, _____ Watson would never, never do that. The end will come today. M has asked me to walk with him to the Reichenbach Falls, _____ is a wild and lonely place. I know he will try to shoot me there, _____ he will not succeed _____ I have put blanks in his gun. He is clever, _____ I will destroy him! It will be the last and greatest success of my life!

3 **Write out the rest of the hidden message in the strange letter that Holmes sent to Watson from France (see page 41).**

The professor is _____.

Now find the hidden message in this note. Who wrote the note, and to whom? When was it written?

London. The last day of the FOURTH *month . . .*
Nobody knows where I am. My friends have hidden me and gone away. They have to go back to Europe. I cannot go with them because of an accident to an old patient – a good friend of mine. I don't have time to worry or even think about who is watching me. I have found the papers. If the police ask, say you know nothing. Tell them everything is fine.

4 **When Watson returned home, perhaps Lestrade came to see him. Put their conversation in the right order, and write in the speakers' names. Lestrade speaks first (number 3).**

1 _____ 'Too far away. I see. Were you and Mr Holmes having an argument, perhaps?'
2 _____ 'Ah, you've heard the news then. Yes, it was terrible – terrible. We have lost a great man, Inspector.'
3 _____ 'Good evening, Dr Watson. I hear you've just returned from Switzerland.'
4 _____ 'No, I couldn't do anything. I was, er, too far away.'
5 _____ 'Mm. But how did it happen? Did Mr Holmes fall from the path?'
6 _____ 'Yes, Inspector, that's right. I got back yesterday.'
7 _____ 'He was a clever man, that's true. Clever . . . and dangerous. Let's hope that we have no more murders in Whitechapel now. Goodnight, Doctor.'
8 _____ 'Yes, er . . . yes, he – he just fell over the edge.'
9 _____ 'And I hear that there has been a sad accident.'
10 _____ 'And you weren't able to help him – to catch him before he fell to his death?'
11 _____ 'An argument? No, of course not! We never argued. Holmes was too clever for me to argue with him.'

5 **Here is a letter to a newspaper, which was written by someone when Watson's box of papers was opened in 1976. Complete the sentences, using as many words as you like.**

When I read the story in your newspaper, I felt very sad and very angry. You say the papers in Dr Watson's box show that

Sherlock Holmes _____, but I am sure that _____. Everyone knows that Sherlock Holmes was _____, who never _____.

I think Dr Watson _____ when he _____. Or perhaps he _____. You say that you have checked _____ but I am sure that most people _____.

6 **Is the Sherlock Holmes in this story very different from the one in Conan Doyle's stories? Use these words to complete the passage below. (Use one word for each gap.)**

appearance, cases, clever, cut, explain, friend, intelligent, knife, murder, recognize, women

In Conan Doyle's books Sherlock Holmes is a very _____ detective. His _____, Dr Watson, who helps him with his _____, is not very _____, and Holmes often has to _____ things to him. Holmes can change his _____ in many different ways, and not even Watson can _____ him. It is true that ACD's Holmes does not like _____, but he does not _____ them and _____ their bodies to pieces with a _____.

7 **Do you think that *The Last Sherlock Holmes Story* is a good title for this book? Here are some other possible titles. Which one do you like best, and why?**

The Death of Sherlock Holmes	The Battle with Moriarty
Who was Jack the Ripper?	No Time to Rip
Inspector Lestrade Fails Again	Dr Watson's Last Case
The Real Sherlock Holmes	The Whitechapel Murders

ABOUT THE AUTHOR

Michael Dibdin (1947–2007) was born in England. He went to school in Northern Ireland, and studied at universities in England and Canada.

The Last Sherlock Holmes Story, which appeared in 1978, was his first book. It is a violent and bloody story, about some murders which really happened in London in the late nineteenth century. The murderer – who was called 'Jack the Ripper' by the newspapers – was never caught. This book is also a very unusual kind of detective story. In it we meet both the famous detective Sherlock Holmes, and Sir Arthur Conan Doyle, the person who wrote the Sherlock Holmes stories. Dibdin's story is about people and events from more than a hundred years ago, but it uses modern ideas about good and evil, and gives us a Sherlock Holmes who can be two different people at the same time.

After writing *The Last Sherlock Holmes Story*, Michael Dibdin spent four years in Italy, where he taught English at the University of Perugia. His second mystery story, *A Rich Full Death*, appeared in 1986. This was followed in 1988 by *Ratking*, which introduced his Italian detective, Inspector Aurelio Zen. He then wrote many more Zen stories as well as other crime novels.

He later lived in the USA, and continued to write crime novels which are intelligent, fast-moving, often amusing, and always full of surprises.

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STARTER • 250 HEADWORDS

present simple – present continuous – imperative – *can/cannot, must – going to* (future) – simple gerunds ...

Her phone is ringing – but where is it?

Sally gets out of bed and looks in her bag. No phone. She looks under the bed. No phone. Then she looks behind the door. There is her phone. Sally picks up her phone and answers it. ***Sally's Phone***

STAGE 1 • 400 HEADWORDS

... past simple – coordination with *and, but, or* – subordination with *before, after, when, because, so* ...

I knew him in Persia. He was a famous builder and I worked with him there. For a time I was his friend, but not for long. When he came to Paris, I came after him – I wanted to watch him. He was a very clever, very dangerous man. ***The Phantom of the Opera***

STAGE 2 • 700 HEADWORDS

... present perfect – *will* (future) – *(don't) have to, must not, could* – comparison of adjectives – simple *if* clauses – past continuous – tag questions – *ask/tell* + infinitive ...

While I was writing these words in my diary, I decided what to do. I must try to escape. I shall try to get down the wall outside. The window is high above the ground, but I have to try. I shall take some of the gold with me – if I escape, perhaps it will be helpful later. ***Dracula***

STAGE 3 • 1000 HEADWORDS

... *should, may* – present perfect continuous – *used to* – past perfect – causative – relative clauses – indirect statements ...

Of course, it was most important that no one should see Colin, Mary, or Dickon entering the secret garden. So Colin gave orders to the gardeners that they must all keep away from that part of the garden in future. ***The Secret Garden***

STAGE 4 • 1400 HEADWORDS

... past perfect continuous – passive (simple forms) – *would* conditional clauses – indirect questions – relatives with *where/when* – gerunds after prepositions/phrases ...

I was glad. Now Hyde could not show his face to the world again. If he did, every honest man in London would be proud to report him to the police. ***Dr Jekyll and Mr Hyde***

STAGE 5 • 1800 HEADWORDS

... future continuous – future perfect – passive (modals, continuous forms) – *would have* conditional clauses – modals + perfect infinitive ...

If he had spoken Estella's name, I would have hit him. I was so angry with him, and so depressed about my future, that I could not eat the breakfast. Instead I went straight to the old house. ***Great Expectations***

STAGE 6 • 2500 HEADWORDS

... passive (infinitives, gerunds) – advanced modal meanings – clauses of concession, condition

When I stepped up to the piano, I was confident. It was as if I knew that the prodigy side of me really did exist. And when I started to play, I was so caught up in how lovely I looked that I didn't worry how I would sound. ***The Joy Luck Club***

Câu chuyện cuối cùng về Sherlock Holmes
Trong suốt năm mươi năm sau cái chết của bác sĩ Watson, một gói giấy tờ do chính ông viết đã được cất giấu trong một chiếc hộp khóa kín. Những giấy tờ này chứa đựng một bản báo cáo phi thường về vụ án Jack the Ripper và những vụ giết người kinh hoàng ở khu Đông London vào năm 1888. Thám tử, tất nhiên, là Sherlock Holmes vĩ đại – nhưng tại sao bản báo cáo này lại được giữ bí mật quá lâu như vậy?

Đây là câu chuyện mà Ngài Arthur Conan Doyle chưa từng viết. Đó là một câu chuyện kỳ lạ và đáng sợ...
(Số từ: 9.680)

Lời nói đầu (Trang 9)

Nhiều người yêu thích những câu chuyện của Ngài Arthur Conan Doyle về thám tử nổi tiếng Sherlock Holmes và người bạn của ông, bác sĩ Watson. Nhưng giờ đây, ai còn nhớ rằng Holmes và Watson là những con người có thật? Mọi người đã quên rằng họ từng sống trước khi Conan Doyle thổi hồn vào họ qua những cuốn sách của mình.

Bác sĩ Watson qua đời vào năm 1926, hưởng thọ bảy mươi ba tuổi. Ông để lại một chiếc hộp khóa kín, cùng với lời dặn rằng nó không được mở trong vòng năm mươi năm.

Trong suốt năm mươi năm, chiếc hộp nằm ẩn mình trong một căn phòng tối dưới tầng hầm của một ngân hàng. Thời gian trôi qua, thế giới thay đổi theo hàng ngàn cách.

Năm 1976, chiếc hộp được mở. Bên trong là một gói giấy tờ. Chúng kể lại một câu chuyện kinh hoàng. Một số người nói rằng câu chuyện này không thể là sự thật. Họ cho rằng Watson đã nói dối, hoặc ông bị bệnh khi viết ra nó. Sau ngần ấy năm, chúng ta không thể chắc chắn. Chúng tôi đã kiểm tra tất cả các dữ kiện có thể. Tất cả những gì chúng tôi biết là câu chuyện này có thể là thật. Nó khả thi. Chúng tôi nghĩ nó có lẽ đúng. Giờ đây, bạn phải đọc và tự mình quyết định.
Các biên tập viên

Lời giới thiệu (Trang 11-15)

Bạn tôi, Arthur Conan Doyle, sẽ kể câu chuyện này hay đến nhường nào! Ông ấy sẽ khiến nó trở nên ly kỳ và hấp dẫn. Tôi không thể làm được như vậy. Tôi không phải là nhà văn. Tôi từng là bác sĩ và lính tráng. Tất cả những gì tôi có thể làm là viết lại bản báo cáo của mình.

Nhưng ai sẽ đọc những dòng chữ này? Thế giới năm 1976 sẽ ra sao? Có lẽ đến lúc đó, chẳng ai còn biết đến cái tên Sherlock Holmes hay Jack the Ripper. Có lẽ tất cả những câu chuyện tuyệt vời của Conan Doyle sẽ bị lãng quên. Có quá nhiều điều cần giải thích. Tôi phải xin người đọc kiên nhẫn!

Tôi đã quen biết và làm việc với Sherlock Holmes được gần bốn năm thì gặp Arthur Conan Doyle – tôi luôn gọi ông ấy là ACD. Cũng như tôi, ông là bác sĩ, và chúng tôi nhanh chóng trở thành bạn tốt. Ông kể tôi nghe những câu chuyện hài hước về đời sống bệnh viện, còn tôi kể ông nghe về quãng thời gian làm bác sĩ quân y ở Afghanistan.

Tôi thường kể ông nghe về Sherlock Holmes. Vào thời điểm đó, hầu hết mọi người chưa từng nghe đến ông. Chỉ có cảnh sát và một vài tên tội phạm biết ông là một thám tử xuất sắc đến nhường nào. ACD dường như rất thích thú với những câu chuyện của tôi. Ông không bao giờ chán khi nghe về một vụ án khác của Holmes.

Chúng tôi gặp nhau nhiều lần và cùng nhau thưởng thức nhiều bữa tối vui vẻ trước khi tôi nhận ra rằng ACD có một sự quan tâm đặc biệt đến Holmes. Ông muốn trở thành nhà văn, và đã đạt được một chút thành công. Giờ đây, ông muốn viết về Holmes, sử dụng các sự kiện có thật từ một vụ án, nhưng thêm vào những ý tưởng của riêng mình. Tôi thấy đây là một ý tưởng tuyệt vời. Tôi vui mừng nghĩ rằng người bạn thân của mình sẽ trở nên nổi tiếng.

Tôi giải thích kế hoạch này cho Holmes. Ông lặng lẽ lắng nghe, điếu tẩu trên tay. Rồi ông nói, "Người bạn của anh, anh ta có viết được không? Anh ta có thể kể một câu chuyện chân thực không? Anh ta có hiểu sự khác biệt giữa sự thật và dối trá không?"

"Tôi nghĩ là có," tôi đáp. "Ông ấy mới bắt đầu viết, nhưng đã bắt đầu trở nên nổi tiếng."

"Nổi tiếng!" Holmes lạnh lùng nói. "Việc ông ta nổi tiếng thì liên quan gì đến tôi? Một nhà văn nổi tiếng có thể nghiêm túc quan tâm đến sự thật của một vụ án của tôi sao?"

Tôi không thể trả lời. Holmes ngồi im lặng, nhìn vào ngọn lửa. Cuối cùng, ông nói, "Thôi được, ông ta có thể thử. Cứ để ông ta làm những gì có thể. Anh có thể gửi cho ông ta ghi chép của anh về vụ án Hope, Watson."

Ngày hôm sau, tôi viết thư cho ACD, và ông bắt đầu viết. Ông gọi câu chuyện là *A Study in Scarlet* (Nghiên cứu trong sắc đỏ). Khi cuốn sách xuất hiện trong các cửa hàng, tôi vội vã đi mua, rồi ngồi hàng giờ trong công viên để đọc. Câu chuyện rất xuất sắc – nhanh, ly kỳ và thông minh. Tôi chạy về phố Baker. Tôi không thể chờ đợi thêm để đưa cuốn sách cho Holmes.

Ông ngẩng đầu lên nhanh chóng khi tôi bước vào phòng.

“Anh về muộn đấy, Watson,” ông nói. “Có phải anh xấu hổ khi đến đây với cuốn sách đó trên tay không?”

“Xấu hổ, Holmes?” tôi kêu lên. “Không! ACD đã làm rất tốt. Tôi thấy anh đã đọc nó. Sao anh lại không thích nó?”

Tôi sớm hối hận vì đã nói.

“Thích nó? Nó là rác rưởi, rác rưởi hoang đường và viển vông. Ông ta đã cẩu thả với sự thật, thêm vào đủ thứ dối trá không cần thiết, và mắc những sai lầm ngu ngốc nhất.”

“Nhưng Holmes...”

“Tôi tự hỏi ông ta là bác sĩ kiểu gì. Tôi thấy tiếc cho bệnh nhân của ông ta. Tôi sẽ không ngạc nhiên nếu nghe rằng ông ta cắt chân một người chỉ vì người đó đau bụng. Rõ ràng ông ta không quan tâm đến sự thật.”

“Holmes,” tôi nói một cách bình tĩnh nhất có thể, “một nhà văn không chỉ báo cáo sự thật. Anh ta phải đảm bảo rằng câu chuyện thú vị để đọc. Tôi chắc anh hiểu điều đó.”

Holmes mỉm cười với tôi một cách ngọt ngào.

“Bạn thân mến,” ông nói. “Tôi quên mất. Anh biết tất cả về văn chương cao cấp. Tôi thật ngu ngốc khi lo lắng về vài sai lầm cẩu thả! Nhưng bạn anh, ông Doyle, đã cho thấy ông ta không hiểu công việc của tôi quan trọng đến mức nào. Ông ta nghĩ rằng những tên tội phạm tôi đối đầu là những kẻ ngu ngốc, tầm thường. Không phải vậy. Tôi chiến đấu với chính cái ác. Ông ta không hiểu điều đó. Cuốn sách này vô giá trị. Vứt nó đi, và cả người bạn nhà văn của anh nữa!”

Tôi tự hỏi phải nói gì với ACD, nhưng không cần lo lắng. *A Study in Scarlet* không thành công, và ông bắt đầu viết về những thứ khác. Vài năm sau, ông quyết định viết lại về Holmes, nhưng vào thời điểm đó, tôi có những mối bận tâm khác. Tôi đã phải lòng cô Mary Morstan. Khi cô ấy đồng ý trở thành vợ tôi, tôi vội vã đi kể với Holmes. Tôi tràn ngập niềm vui.

Tôi vẫn còn nghe thấy giọng nói lạnh lùng, ngạc nhiên của ông khi ông nói, “Tôi không thể giả vờ là tôi vui về chuyện này.”

Điều này làm tôi tổn thương khủng khiếp, nhưng tôi cố gắng cười.

“Thôi nào, Holmes,” tôi nói, “tôi hy vọng anh sẽ không quá cô đơn khi tôi về nhà với vợ mình.”

Một cái bóng lướt qua khuôn mặt ông.

“Ồ không, Watson,” ông nói. “Tôi vẫn còn lọ cocaine của mình.”

Ông ấy đang cầu xin tôi giúp đỡ sao? Liệu vẫn còn khả năng để cứu ông ấy? Có lẽ. Trong lòng, tôi chỉ biết rằng người bạn thân của tôi cần tôi, và tôi đã thất bại với ông ấy.

Chương 1: Những vụ giết người đầu tiên (Trang 16-22)

Sherlock Holmes trở thành thám tử vào năm 1877, bốn năm trước khi tôi gặp ông. Ban đầu, ông thích thú với mọi vụ án, nhưng chẳng bao lâu ông bắt đầu thấy công việc này dễ dàng. Mười năm sau, ông nổi tiếng, nhưng ông không hạnh phúc và chán nản.

“Tội phạm thời nay chậm chạp và ngu ngốc đến đau đớn,” ông thường nói. “Tôi cần một vụ án thú vị, Watson, một vụ khiến tôi phải suy nghĩ. Chẳng lẽ ngày nay không còn tên trộm hay kẻ giết người thông minh nào trên đời sao?”

Thật nguy hiểm khi một người thông minh như Holmes trở nên chán nản. Có những ngày ông trở nên bạo lực, và một lần ông bắn vài viên đạn vào tường phòng mình. Ông cũng bắt đầu sử dụng cocaine.

Người đọc của tôi có biết về cocaine không, tôi tự hỏi? Có lẽ nó không còn được dùng ở thế giới năm 1976. Đó là một loại thuốc hữu ích, và các bác sĩ đúng đắn khi dùng nó cho bệnh nhân đang đau đớn. Nhưng Holmes không mắc bệnh về thể chất. Ông dùng cocaine như một chất gây nghiện, vì ông thích nó. Nó khiến những ngày dài trở nên thú vị hơn. Chẳng bao lâu, ông cần nó mỗi ngày và không thể sống thiếu nó.

Tôi bảo ông dừng lại, nhưng ông chỉ cười vào mặt tôi. “Bạn thân mến, tôi ước gì tôi có thể! Chỉ cần mang đến cho tôi một vụ án thú vị, một vấn đề khó khăn, và tôi sẽ quên cocaine của mình!”

Một ngày năm 1888, một lá thư từ Scotland Yard được gửi đến. Khi Holmes mở nó, ông cười lớn và nhảy bật dậy.

“Thanh tra Lestrade muốn gặp tôi,” ông nói. “Cảnh sát cần sự giúp đỡ của tôi, Watson. Tất nhiên, anh biết rằng có kẻ đang giết phụ nữ ở Whitechapel chứ?”

“Tất nhiên,” tôi đáp. “Báo chí đầy rẫy tin tức về việc đó. Ba phụ nữ đã chết, và cảnh sát dường như không thể tìm ra kẻ giết người. Ai cũng biết chuyện này. Mạng sống ở Whitechapel rẻ mạt đối với những phụ nữ như vậy. Điều gì khiến anh quan tâm đến cái chết khốn khổ của họ?”

“Đó là một vụ án phi thường, Watson,” Holmes kêu lên. “Tôi đã nghiên cứu nó. Tôi biết cảnh sát sẽ cần sự giúp đỡ của tôi. Tôi có nên kể anh nghe sự thật không?”

“Làm ơn đi!” tôi nói. Liệu đây có phải là một trong những vụ án lớn của Sherlock Holmes? Tôi hy vọng cuối cùng ông đã tìm thấy thứ gì đó khiến ông hứng thú.

“Những phụ nữ đã chết đều nghèo, và không còn trẻ hay đẹp,” ông kể tôi. “Vì vậy, họ không bị giết vì tiền hay tình yêu. Tại sao họ bị giết? Đó là một bí ẩn. Còn một bí ẩn nữa. Mỗi phụ nữ đều bị giết bằng dao. Từ ‘giết’, Watson, không thể mô tả những cách thức bạo lực và kinh hoàng mà họ bị sát hại. Họ bị cắt xẻ như thịt. Bụng của một người bị mổ ra, đầu của một người khác gần như bị cắt rời khỏi cơ thể. Nhưng đó chưa phải là điều tồi tệ nhất. Có những thứ mà ngay cả báo chí cũng không dám mô tả.”

Ông đưa tôi xem một báo cáo y khoa về một trong những thi thể. Khi đọc, tôi cảm thấy một cảm giác bệnh hoạn trỗi dậy.

“Con người nào có thể làm điều này?” tôi hỏi. “Hắn có lý do gì để làm điều này với một phụ nữ? Tại sao, Holmes, tại sao?”

Ông mỉm cười lạnh lùng với tôi.

“Tại sao ư? Đó là điều thực sự thú vị của vụ án này. Bản thân những cái chết này không quan trọng. Những phụ nữ như vậy bị giết mỗi tuần. Nhưng tại sao kẻ giết người này lại cắt xẻ họ? Tại sao xé nát cơ thể họ bằng dao? Đó là câu hỏi khiến vụ án này trở nên hấp dẫn!”

Nếu có ai có thể ngăn chặn những vụ giết người kinh hoàng này, thì đó chính là Holmes, tôi nghĩ. Vụ án này có thể trở thành thành công lớn nhất của ông.

Ngay lúc đó, có tiếng gõ cửa.

“A, mời vào, Thanh tra,” Holmes nói. “Tôi hiểu rằng cuối cùng ông đã quyết định nhờ tôi giúp bắt kẻ giết người ở Whitechapel.”

Thanh tra Lestrade trông không vui lắm. “Không hẳn vậy, ông Holmes,” ông ta nói. “Tôi chỉ đi ngang qua phố Baker, và tôi biết ông thích thú với những vụ án như thế này.”

“Thật tử tế!” Holmes nói. “Làm ơn cho chúng tôi biết. Các ông đã bắt kẻ giết người khi nào vậy? Tôi phải nói rằng tôi hơi buồn, khi biết các ông đã làm được mà không cần đến tôi.”

“Chúng tôi chưa bắt được ai,” Lestrade nói, “nhưng tôi rất hy vọng, ông Holmes. Ông thấy đấy, tôi có trong túi một lá thư từ chính kẻ giết người.”

Nụ cười biến mất khỏi khuôn mặt Holmes. Ông đột nhiên trở nên nghiêm túc.

“Tôi có thể xem lá thư không?” ông hỏi.

Lá thư được viết bằng mực đỏ, và tên ở dưới cùng là ‘Jack the Ripper’. Tôi vẫn nhớ một phần nội dung của nó:

Tôi yêu công việc của mình. Con dao của tôi sắc bén và sẵn sàng cho công việc tiếp theo. Tôi không thể chờ đợi để xé nát lần nữa.

Holmes quay sang Lestrade. “Các ông đang làm gì để ngăn chặn kẻ giết người này?” ông hỏi. “Rõ ràng là hắn sẽ sớm giết người lần nữa.”

“Chúng tôi sẽ điều tất cả các cảnh sát bổ sung đến Whitechapel vào ban đêm,” Lestrade nói. “Và chúng tôi có một bất ngờ nhỏ cho Jack the Ripper.” Ông ta nhìn chúng tôi một cách quan trọng. “Một số cảnh sát giỏi và dũng cảm nhất của chúng tôi sẽ mặc đồ phụ nữ,” ông ta nói. “Chúng tôi sẽ không ngừng lại để bắt tên tội phạm này.”

Có một khoảnh khắc im lặng. Rồi Holmes và tôi nhìn nhau, và cả hai bắt đầu cười. Chúng tôi không thể dừng lại.

Lestrade đỏ mặt. “Tôi thấy các ông thấy việc giết người rất buồn cười,” ông ta nói. “Các ông không muốn làm việc với chúng tôi. Thôi được, tôi là người bận rộn. Tôi phải đi đây. Tạm biệt, ông Holmes. Tạm biệt, bác sĩ.”

Holmes lập tức ngừng cười.

“Thanh tra,” ông nói, “tôi rất muốn làm việc với ông. Hãy gặp nhau chiều nay để bàn kế hoạch.”

Điều này khiến Lestrade vui hơn nhiều.

Khi ông ta rời đi, tôi nói với Holmes, “Anh đã cười nhạo cảnh sát, nhưng anh có ý tưởng gì về những tội ác này? Anh nghĩ kẻ giết người là ai?”

“Tôi không biết hắn là ai, Watson,” ông nói với tôi, “nhưng tôi tin rằng tôi biết hắn là loại người gì. Hắn quá thông minh, quá đặc biệt một kẻ giết người để người bạn tốt của chúng ta, Lestrade, và những viên cảnh sát mặc váy của ông ta có thể bắt được. Không, hắn sẽ là của tôi. Hắn là tên tội phạm mà tôi đã chờ đợi. Phá hủy hắn sẽ là thành công lớn nhất trong đời tôi. Tôi mơ về điều đó, Watson! Tôi phải phá hủy hắn! Tôi không thể thất bại!”

Ông run lên vì phấn khích. Tôi chưa từng thấy ông như thế này bao giờ.

Chiều hôm đó, ông đến Scotland Yard. Khi về nhà, ông rất trầm lặng. Ngày hôm sau, ông xuất hiện trong bộ quần áo cũ, bẩn thỉu.

“Tôi sẽ đến Whitechapel,” ông nói với tôi. “Như anh biết, tôi có phòng ở nhiều nơi trong London. Trong ba ngày tới, tôi sẽ sống giữa những người nghèo ở Whitechapel. Không ai sẽ biết tôi là ai. Tôi sẽ nói chuyện với họ và lắng nghe mọi thứ họ kể.”

“Tôi có thể đi cùng không?” tôi hỏi, nhưng ông nói, “Không, Watson, anh không thể. Nếu có một vụ giết người, tôi sẽ gọi anh. Tôi sẽ cần sự giúp đỡ của anh, bạn già, đừng lo về chuyện đó!”

Tôi trải qua một buổi tối cô đơn ở phố Baker. Tôi đang ngủ thì vào lúc hai giờ rưỡi sáng, một chiếc xe ngựa đến để đưa tôi đến Whitechapel. Một phụ nữ khác đã chết một cách bạo lực.

Khi tôi đi qua những con phố tối tăm, vắng vẻ, London dường như là một nơi kỳ lạ và ma quái – nó nằm đó như cơ thể của một con thú khổng lồ, không ngủ mà đã chết.

Người lái xe đưa tôi về phía đông, tới những khu vực nghèo nhất của thành phố. Ông ta dừng lại ở một con hẻm hẹp gần phố Leadenhall. Tôi thấy một nhóm cảnh sát đứng dưới ánh đèn, và tiến đến gần họ. Holmes không ở đó, nhưng tôi được giới thiệu với bác sĩ cảnh sát. Ông ta đề nghị đưa tôi xem thi thể.

"Tôi biết ông là bác sĩ," ông ta nói, "nhưng tôi phải cảnh báo ông. Ông chưa từng thấy thứ gì như thế này."

Ông ta dẫn tôi đến một góc tối, nơi có thứ gì đó nằm trên mặt đất, được che phủ. Ông ta giơ đèn lên cho tôi nhìn và kéo tấm phủ ra.

Không từ ngữ nào có thể mô tả sự kinh hoàng của những gì tôi thấy. Trong một khoảnh khắc, đầu tôi quay cuồng, tôi bắt đầu run và sợ rằng mình sẽ ngã. Thứ nằm trên mặt đất từng là một phụ nữ, nhưng giờ không còn là phụ nữ nữa. Nó chỉ là máu và thịt, bị cắt mở và xé nát với một sự bạo lực kinh khủng, không tự nhiên. Giờ tôi hiểu tại sao kẻ giết người tự gọi mình là Jack the Ripper.

Bác sĩ che thi thể lại, và tôi bước trở lại nhóm cảnh sát.

"Ông có thấy ông Holmes không?" tôi hỏi một người trong số họ.

"Ồ có, thưa ông," anh ta nói. "Ông ấy ở đây cùng Thanh tra Lestrade. Họ đến thẳng từ vụ giết người khác."

"Vụ giết người khác!" tôi kêu lên. "Có hơn một vụ giết người đêm nay sao?"

"Sao, vâng, thưa ông. Ông không biết sao?"

Chương 2: Giáo sư Moriarty (Trang 23-29)

"Đó là chữ viết của kẻ giết người," Holmes nói. "Giống như trong lá thư mà Lestrade đã cho chúng ta xem."

"Chuyện gì đang xảy ra vậy?" tôi kêu lên. "Tôi không thể hiểu kẻ giết người này muốn gì."

"Hắn muốn mọi người sợ hãi hắn," Holmes nói với tôi. "Hắn muốn trở thành kẻ giết người tàn ác nhất trên thế giới. Hắn phải giết hai phụ nữ tối nay, vì hắn không có thời gian để cắt xẻ thi thể của người đầu tiên. Tôi nghĩ hắn nghe thấy ai đó đến,

và hắn phải bỏ lại thi thể để chạy trốn. Rồi hắn giết lần thứ hai, và cắt xẻ thi thể người phụ nữ đó như cách chúng ta đã thấy."

Cả hai chúng tôi đều im lặng khi chiếc xe ngựa đưa chúng tôi trở về phố Baker, xa khỏi những con phố hẹp, bẩn thỉu ở phía đông London.

Tôi không thể ngủ đêm đó. Mỗi lần nhắm mắt, tôi lại thấy thi thể của một phụ nữ nằm trong góc tối, phủ đầy máu.

Sherlock Holmes bận rộn với các vụ án khác trong ba tuần tiếp theo. Không có vụ giết người mới nào ở Whitechapel, nhưng mọi người sợ hãi và tức giận với cảnh sát, những người chẳng tiến gần hơn đến việc tìm ra kẻ giết người.

Cuộc sống của tôi khá hạnh phúc. Tôi đến thăm Mary Morstan yêu dấu của mình, và giữ bí mật chuyến thăm này với Holmes – điều này khiến tôi cảm thấy mình thông minh một cách bất thường!

Một ngày nọ, Holmes và tôi vừa ăn sáng xong. Ông đang đứng cạnh cửa sổ, thì đột nhiên ông kêu lên.

"Chuyện gì vậy, Holmes?" tôi hỏi. "Có chuyện gì sao?"

Ông quay về phía tôi. Khuôn mặt ông trắng bệch và ánh mắt thật kinh hoàng.

"Tôi có thể xin một giờ thời gian của anh không, Watson?" ông hỏi bằng giọng trầm.

"Tất nhiên, nhưng..."

"Vậy thì lấy mũ và áo khoác của anh."

Ông chạy ra khỏi nhà. Tôi vội vã theo sau, và hai giờ tiếp theo trôi qua trong một cuộc rượt đuổi điên cuồng khắp London. Chúng tôi nhảy lên xe ngựa, rồi lại nhảy xuống, lên tàu hỏa, chạy qua những con phố hẹp, vào và ra khỏi một khách sạn lớn. Cuối cùng, chúng tôi dừng lại trong sự yên bình của một công viên London.

"Anh là một người bạn thực sự, Watson," Holmes nói cuối cùng. "Anh đi cùng tôi mà không hề hỏi gì. Anh có nhận ra rằng có ai đó đang theo dõi chúng ta không?"

"Tôi nghĩ vậy. Nhưng là ai?"

"Anh không đoán được sao?"

"Không."

"Hắn tự gọi mình là Jack the Ripper."

"Holmes!" Trong một khoảnh khắc, tôi thấy khó nói. Rồi tôi hỏi, "Anh có nhìn thấy hắn qua cửa sổ không? Hắn ở đâu?"

“Trong ngôi nhà trống đối diện nhà chúng ta. Hắn đang theo dõi phòng của chúng ta, Watson. Hắn biết rằng tôi đang tìm hắn. Chúng ta phải rất cẩn thận. Hắn là một trong những tên tội phạm nguy hiểm nhất ở châu Âu.”

“Nhưng hắn là ai?” tôi kêu lên.

“Anh đã từng nghe đến Giáo sư Moriarty chưa?”

BOOKWORMS · CRIME & MYSTERY · STAGE 3

Goldfish

RAYMOND CHANDLER

Retold by Christine Lindop

The Leander pearls were stolen nineteen years ago. The thief was caught, but the pearls were never found, and there is still a $25,000 reward for anyone who finds them. Then somebody comes to private detective Carmady with a story about a guy who knows where the pearls are hidden.

Carmady agrees to talk to the guy who says he knows. But he finds him dead in his bed, with burned feet, and it seems there are quite a lot of people in Los Angeles who have heard the story, and who are out looking for the Leander pearls . . .

BOOKWORMS · THRILLER & ADVENTURE · STAGE 3

Chemical Secret

TIM VICARY

The job was too good. There had to be a problem – and there was.

John Duncan was an honest man, but he needed money. He had children to look after. He was ready to do anything, and his bosses knew it.

They gave him the job because he couldn't say no; he couldn't afford to be honest. And the job was like a poison inside him. It changed him and blinded him, so that he couldn't see the real poison – until it was too late.